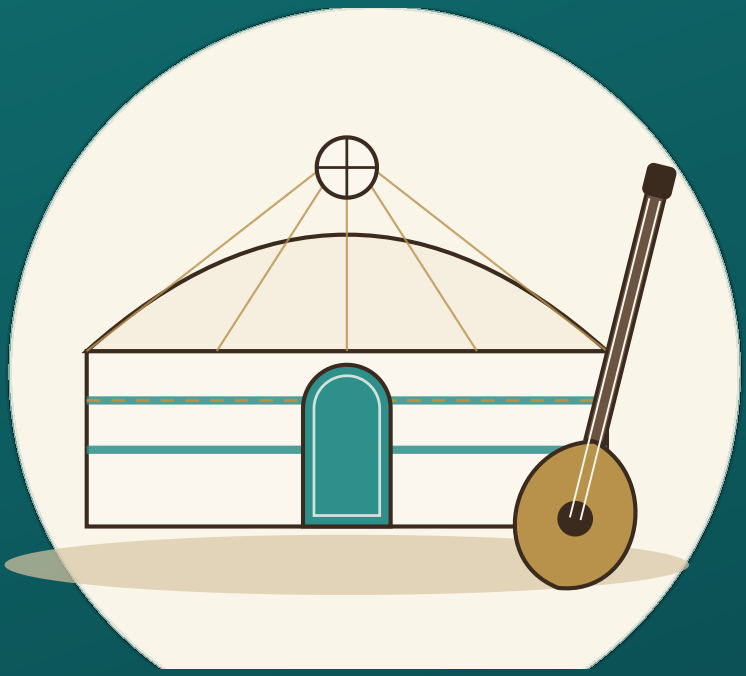
AN INTERACTIVE BOOK

KAZAKH ETHNOGRAPHIC TERMS: AN AI-BASED QR DICTIONARY

Қазақ мұрасы



34 words of the steppe in two parts.
Read, scan the QR codes and explore every word in 3D.

Open the interactive book
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **Read** each word: its story, pictures and facts.
2. **Scan** the QR code at the bottom of the page with a phone camera.
3. **Explore** the 3D model and listen to the recorded word.

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Open the interactive book
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/#contents

PART 1

Textbook Vocabulary

Оқулық сөздігі

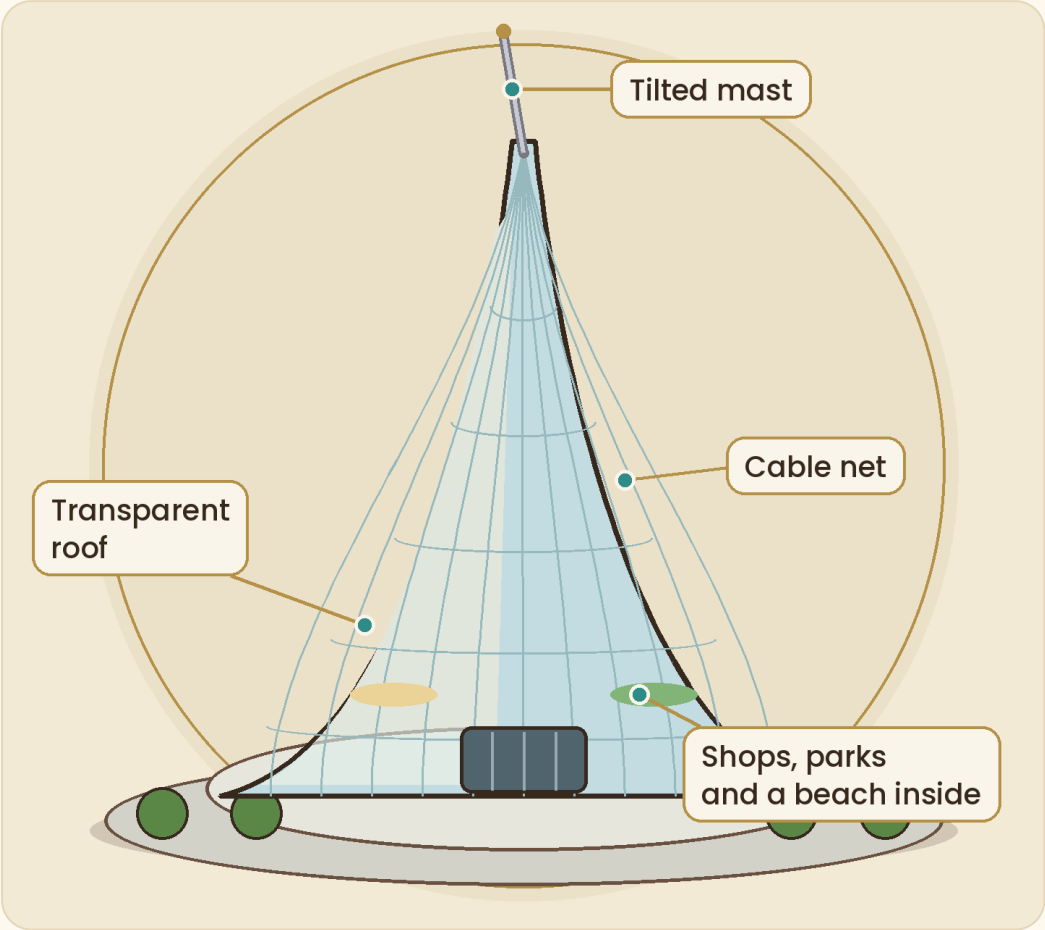
Six words from the textbook: famous places, a legend, the home of the nomads and an everyday drink.

1. **Khan Shatyr**
   Хан Шатыр · *han shatır*
2. **Kiiz Ui**
   Киіз үй · *kiíz üy*
3. **Kyz Zhibek**
   Қыз Жібек · *qız zhíbek*
4. **Aisha Bibi**
   Айша бибі · *aysha bíbí*
5. **Karakhan**
   Қарахан · *qarahan*
6. **Ayran**
   Айран · *ayran*

Part 1 in the interactive book
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/#part-1

Khan Shatyr Хан Шатыр · *han shatır*

The royal tent of Astana



Khan Shatyr, whose name means "the khan's tent", is one of the best-known buildings of Astana. It was designed by the British architect Norman Foster and opened in 2010. Its shape recalls a nomadic tent: a tall steel mast rises in the middle, and a net of cables holds a light, transparent roof that lets the daylight in. Under this roof, the air stays warm even in the freezing Astana winter. Inside there are shops, cafés, a park with paths and even an indoor beach. Khan Shatyr shows how the image of the old nomadic tent can inspire modern architecture.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The name Khan Shatyr means "the khan's tent" or "royal tent".
- The building was designed by Foster + Partners and opened in 2010.
- Its transparent roof keeps a warm climate inside, even when it is very cold outside.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

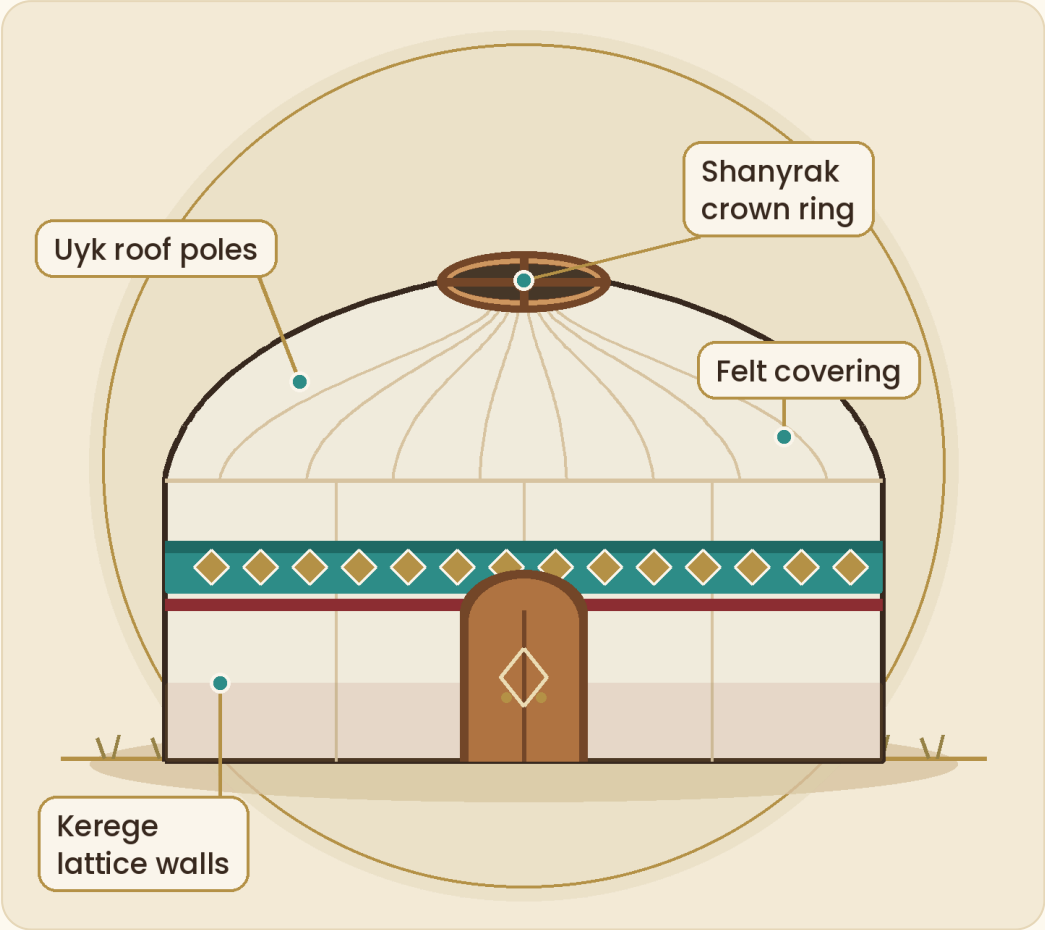
On a freezing winter day, families in Astana stroll through **Khan Shatyr** *in light clothes, because the transparent tent keeps the air inside warm.*

Scan to explore Khan Shatyr in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/khan-shatyr

Kiiz Ui Киіз үй · *kiíz üy*

The portable home of the nomads



The Kazakh yurt, called kiiz ui, or "felt house", is the portable home of the steppe. Its frame is built from kerege, folding lattice walls of willow, joined by uyk, long roof poles that rise like the ribs of an umbrella to meet in the shanyraq, the wooden ring at the crown. Thick felt covers the frame, keeping the interior warm in winter and cool in summer. A family could take a yurt down and raise it again within hours, moving with the seasons between pastures. The shanyraq, which lets in light and releases smoke, is a symbol of home and family.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The kerege are the folding lattice walls; the uyk are the roof poles; the shanyraq is the crown ring.
- The shanyraq is a symbol of the family home and is often handed down through generations.
- Felt coverings can be added or removed to adapt the yurt to the weather.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

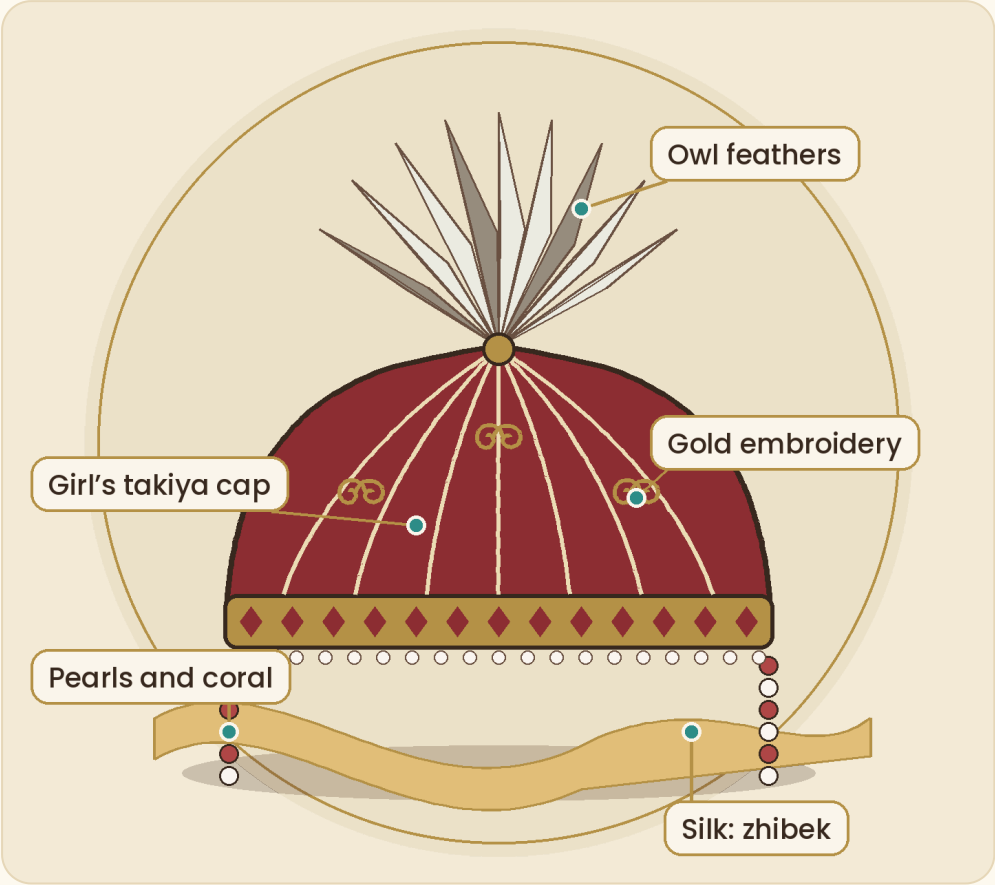
As a guest, you enter the **kiiz ui** *and sit at a round low table. Colourful hand-crafted rugs and blankets cover the floor and walls, and the felt protects the family from the weather.*

Scan to explore Kiiz Ui in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/yurt

Kyz Zhibek Қыз Жібек · *qız zhíbek*

The silk maiden of the great love epic



Kyz Zhibek, "the silk maiden", is the heroine of one of the best-loved Kazakh lyric epics. The poem tells of the young hero Tolegen, who travels far across the steppe to find the beautiful Zhibek. The two fall in love, but jealousy and rivalry lead to tragedy: Tolegen is killed on his way back to his bride. The story is told in verse by akyns and zhyraus and has been passed down from generation to generation. In the twentieth century it became the first Kazakh opera, with a libretto by the writer Gabit Musirepov, and later a much-loved film. Zhibek is remembered for her beauty, loyalty and courage.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Zhibek means "silk", a word that praises her beauty and grace.
- The opera "Kyz Zhibek", with a libretto by Gabit Musirepov, is considered the first Kazakh opera.
- Girls in the epic wear a takiya, a cap often decorated with owl feathers, embroidery and beads.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

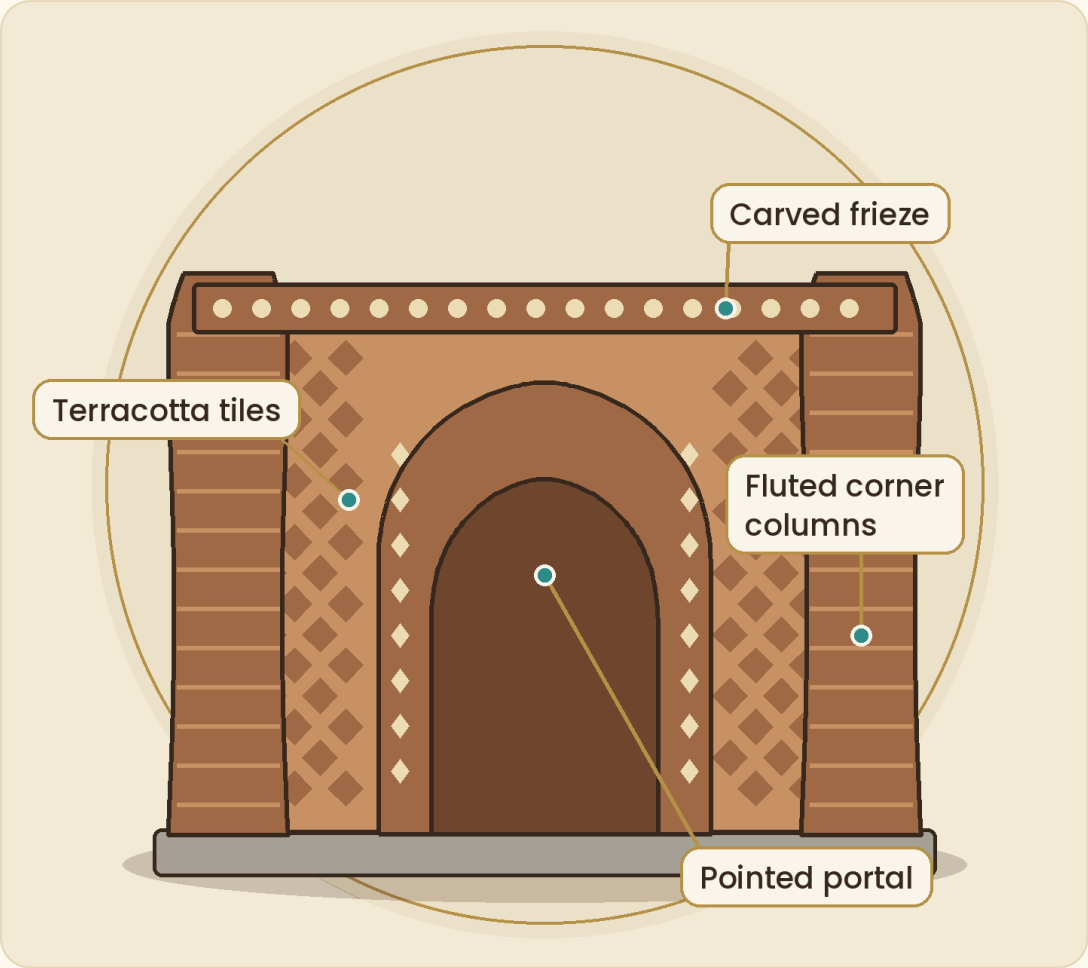
At a festival, an akyn sings the story of **Kyz Zhibek** *to the dombra, and the audience listens to the tale of love and loyalty.*

Scan to explore Kyz Zhibek in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/kyz-zhibek

Aisha Bibi Айша бибі · *aysha bíbí*

A monument to faithful love



The mausoleum of Aisha Bibi stands near the city of Taraz, in the village that bears her name. It was built in the eleventh or twelfth century and is famous for its walls of carved terracotta tiles, covered with dozens of different geometric and plant patterns. Legend says that Aisha, the daughter of a learned man, loved Karakhan, the ruler of Taraz. On her way to marry him she was bitten by a snake and died. In his grief, Karakhan built this beautiful mausoleum over her grave. Today it is a protected monument of Kazakh history, and young couples visit it as a symbol of faithful love.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Its walls are covered with carved terracotta tiles in many different patterns.
- Nearby stands the mausoleum of Babaji Khatun, said to be Aisha's nanny.
- The legend of Aisha Bibi is linked with Karakhan, whose mausoleum stands in Taraz.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

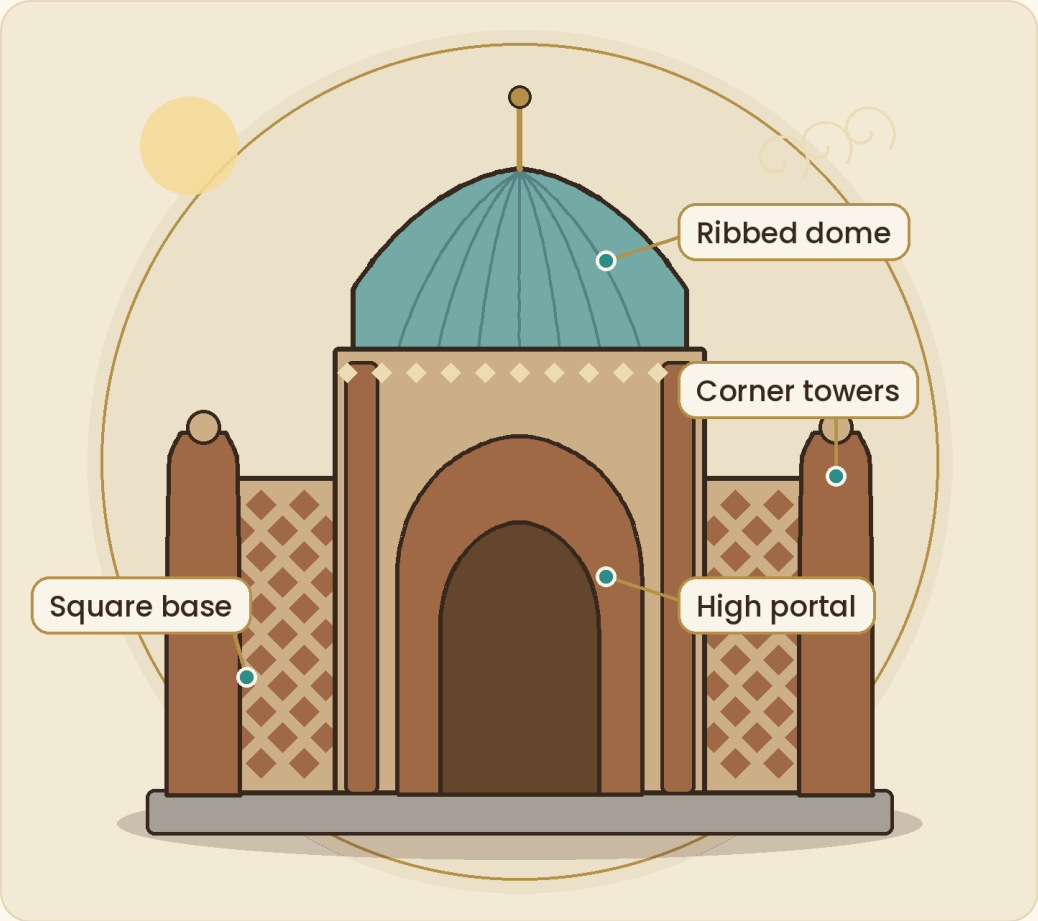
Young couples visiting Taraz stop at **Aisha Bibi** *to admire the carved tiles and hear the legend of faithful love.*

Scan to explore Aisha Bibi in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/aisha-bibi

Karakhan Қарахан · *qarahan*

The mausoleum of the holy ruler of Taraz



The mausoleum of Karakhan stands in the centre of Taraz, one of the oldest cities of Kazakhstan. It was first built in the eleventh century over the grave of a ruler of the Karakhanid state, who is remembered in legend as a wise and just khan. People called him Aulie-Ata, "the holy father", and for many years the city itself carried this name. The building has a square base, a high portal and a dome, and was rebuilt on its old foundations at the beginning of the twentieth century. Legend links Karakhan with Aisha Bibi, the bride he lost, and the two monuments are often visited together.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Karakhan was honoured as Aulie-Ata, "the holy father", and Taraz was once named after him.
- The Karakhanids ruled a large state in Central Asia in the tenth to thirteenth centuries.
- The mausoleum was rebuilt on its medieval foundations in the early twentieth century.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

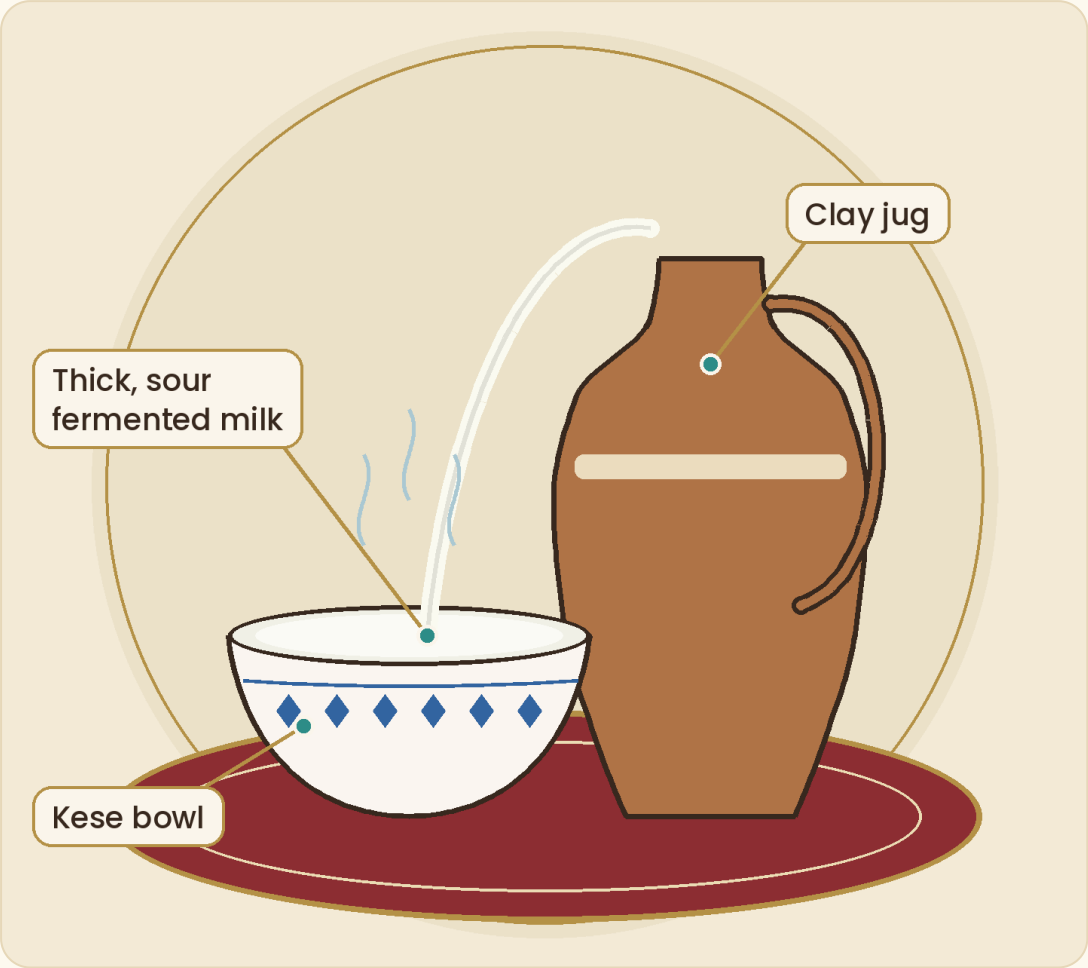
In Taraz, guides tell how the ruler **Karakhan** *built a mausoleum in memory of his beloved Aisha.*

Scan to explore Karakhan in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/karakhan

Ayran Айран · *ayran*

The cool sour milk of summer



Ayran is a traditional Kazakh drink made from fermented cow's, sheep's or goat's milk. The milk is boiled, cooled until it is warm, and then a little old ayran, called the starter, is stirred in. After some hours it thickens and becomes pleasantly sour. Ayran is drunk on its own, mixed with cold water on hot days, or poured over food. It quenches thirst, keeps well and is good for digestion, so it was always at hand in the yurt. Ayran is also the beginning of other dairy foods: when it is strained and dried, it becomes qurt, the hard cheese balls that nomads carried on long journeys.

GOOD TO KNOW

- A spoonful of the previous day's ayran is used as a starter for the next batch.
- Ayran mixed with cold water is a favourite summer drink.
- Strained and dried ayran is used to make qurt.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

On a hot summer day, a guest in the yurt is offered a bowl of cold **ayran** *mixed with water.*

Scan to explore Ayran in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/airan

PART 2

Proposed Vocabulary

Ұсынылған сөздік

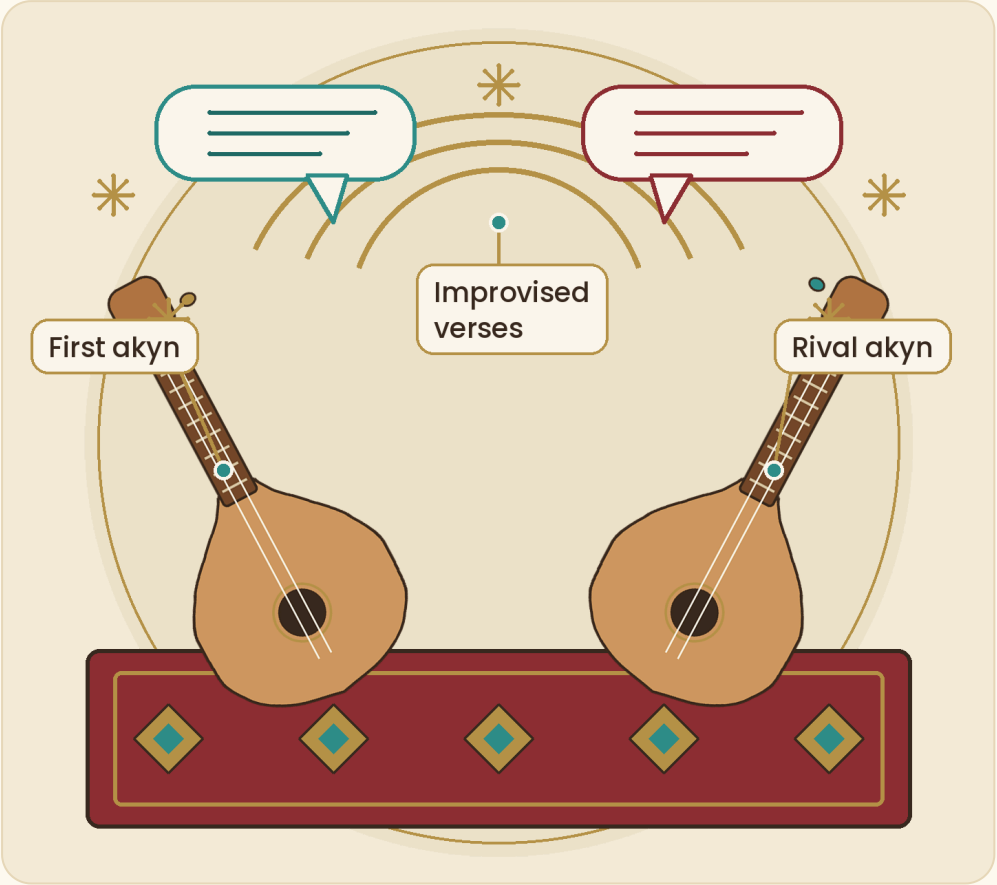
More words from life on the steppe: games and contests, food and drink, crafts, journeys and the seasons of nomadic life.

7	**Aitys** Айтыс · *aytıs*	8	**Asyk** Асық · *asıq*	9	**At Arba** Ат арба · *at arba*
10	**Baige** Бәйге · *bäyge*	11	**Baursak** Бауырсақ · *bauırsaq*	12	**Besik** Бесік · *besík*
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34	**Beshbarmak** Бесбармақ · *besbarmaq*				

Part 2 in the interactive book
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/#part-2

Aitys Айтыс · *aytıs*

A duel of poets



Aitys is a contest of improvised poetry. Two akyns, poet-singers, sit facing each other with their dombras and take turns singing verses that they make up on the spot. Each must answer the rival quickly, wittily and in rhyme, praising their own people, joking, arguing and asking sharp questions. The audience listens closely and decides who was wiser and quicker. Aitys was performed at feasts and gatherings, and great akyns such as Suyunbai Aronuly and Zhambyl Zhabayev became famous through it. Today aitys competitions are held on large stages and shown on television. Aitys is recognised by UNESCO as part of the intangible cultural heritage of humanity.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The verses in aitys are improvised, not learned by heart.
- Aitys was inscribed on the UNESCO intangible heritage list in 2015.
- Akyns often accompany themselves on the dombra.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

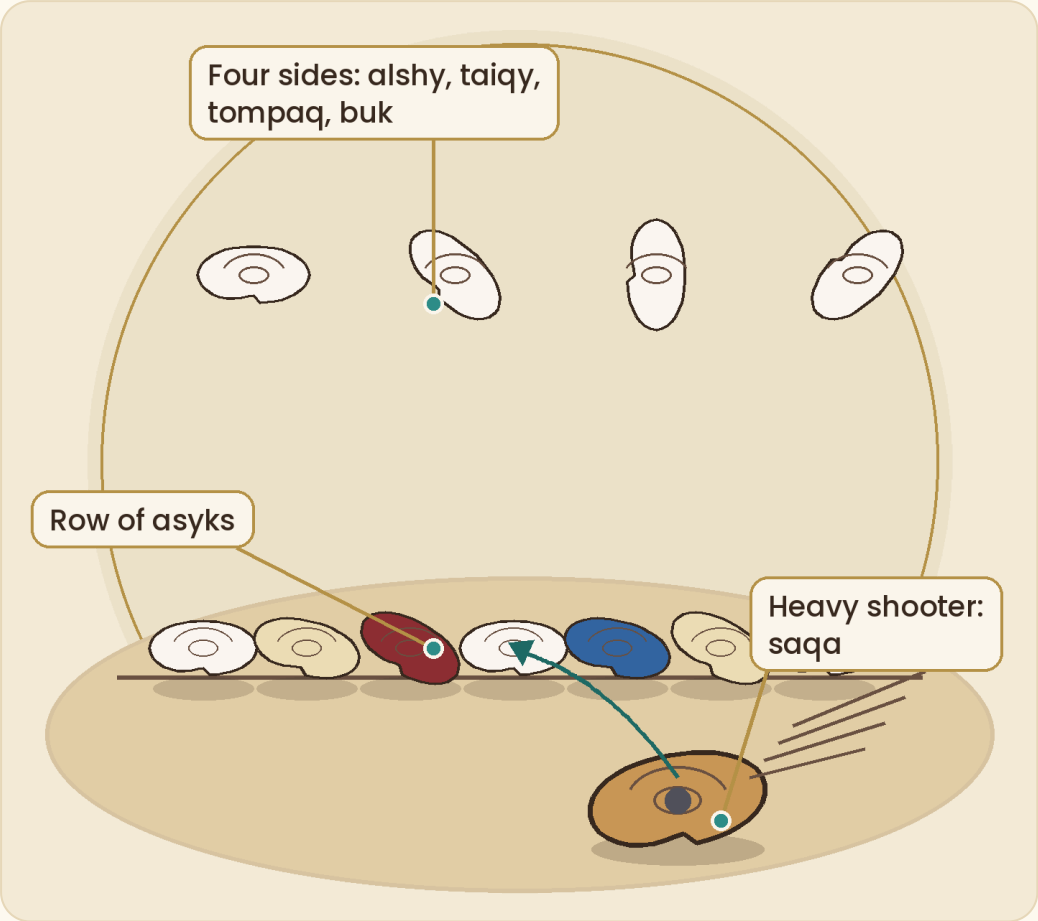
At a holiday, two akyns face each other and answer each other's verses with quick wit in an **aitys** *while the crowd cheers.*

Scan to explore Aitys in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/aitys

Asyk Асық · *asıq*

The knucklebone game



An asyk is the small knucklebone of a sheep. For centuries Kazakh children have used asyks to play many games. The best known is asyk atu, "shooting asyks": players set a row of asyks on the ground and try to knock them out with a heavier shooter called the saqa, often filled with lead. Each side of an asyk has its own name, and the way it lands matters in the game. Playing asyk trains a good eye, a steady hand and patience, and children kept their asyks in special bags and painted the best ones. Asyk games are recognised by UNESCO as part of the intangible cultural heritage of humanity.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The heavy shooting piece is called the saqa.
- The four sides of an asyk have their own names, such as alshy and taiqy.
- Kazakh traditional asyk games were added to the UNESCO intangible heritage list in 2017.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

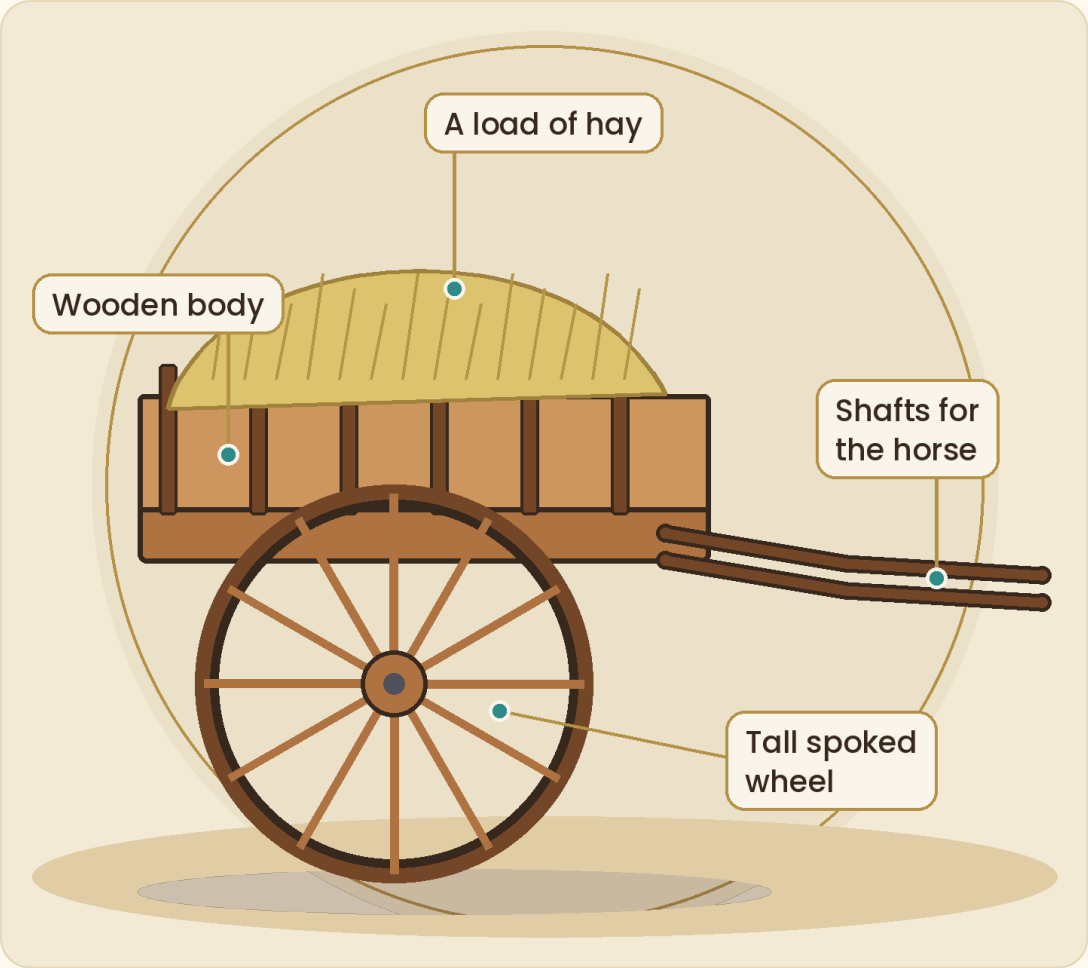
Children sit in a circle on the ground and throw the **asyk** *bones, and every throw decides who wins the game.*

Scan to explore Asyk in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/asyk

At Arba Ат арба · *at arba*

The horse-drawn cart



An at arba is a cart drawn by a horse. It has a wooden body and two or four tall wooden wheels with strong spokes, which roll easily over rough steppe roads and through mud and shallow rivers. Two long shafts are fastened to the horse's harness. Settled villages and families in winter quarters used the at arba to carry hay, firewood, water, grain and the harvest, and to take people to the market or to a celebration. Making a good cart, and especially its wheels, was the work of a skilled master. Today the at arba is still seen in villages and at festivals.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Tall wheels help the cart cross rough ground, mud and streams.
- The cart is joined to the horse with two long shafts and a harness.
- Making strong wooden wheels required a skilled craftsman.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

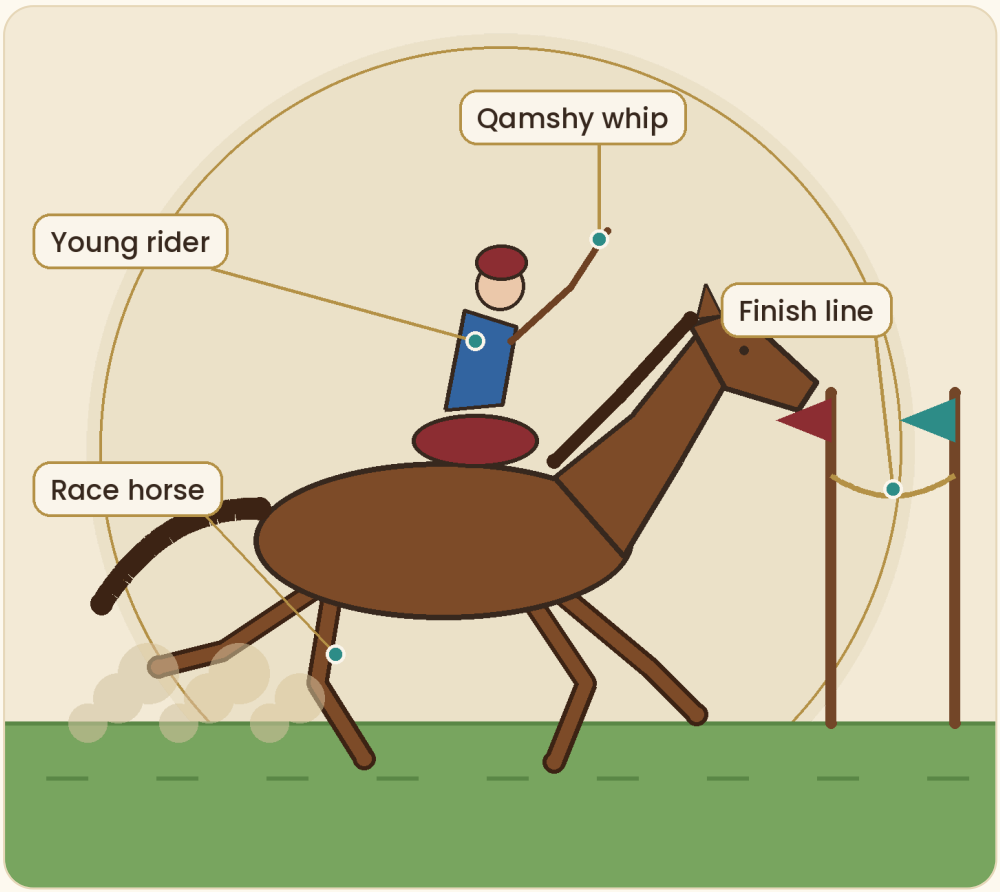
Before cars and roads, a family loaded its belongings onto an **at arba**, *a cart pulled by a horse.*

Scan to explore At Arba in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/at-arba

Baige Бәйге · *bäyge*

The long-distance horse race



Baige is the traditional Kazakh horse race, held at weddings, holidays such as Nauryz, and large celebrations. Unlike short races on a track, a baige can cover many kilometres across the open steppe, testing the endurance of the horses as much as their speed. The riders are often light, skilful boys, and the horses are prepared for weeks in advance. The whole crowd cheers as the riders appear on the horizon. Winning a baige brought honour to the horse's owner and a valuable prize. The qamshy, a braided leather whip, is the rider's constant companion and a symbol of the horseman.

GOOD TO KNOW

- A baige can be many kilometres long and tests the endurance of horses.
- Riders are often young boys, because a light rider helps the horse.
- The qamshy, a braided whip, is a symbol of the Kazakh horseman.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

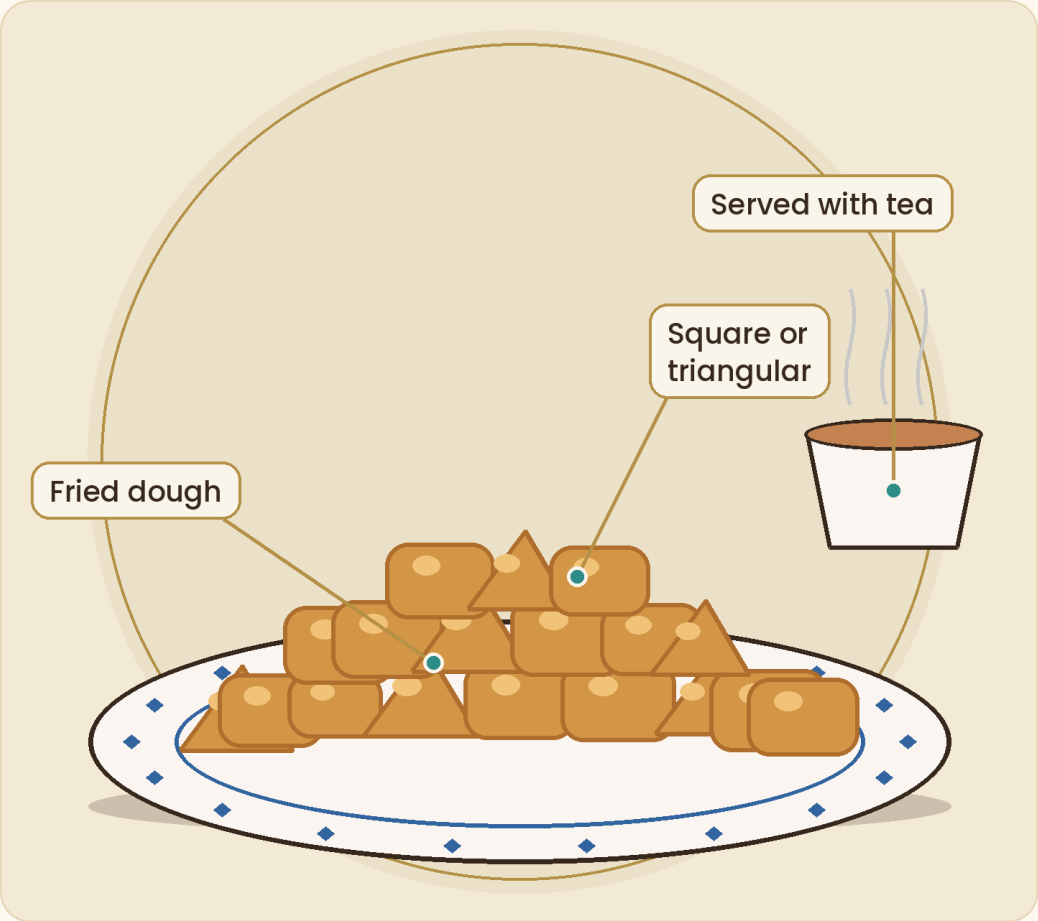
At a wedding or a holiday, men ride out on their horses for the **baige**, *and the fastest, best-trained horse brings honour to its owner.*

Scan to explore Baige in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/baige

Baursak Бауырсақ · *bauırsaq*

Golden bread of the dastarkhan



Baursak is fried dough, golden on the outside and soft inside. The dough is made from flour, milk or water, yeast and a little sugar, rolled out and cut into small squares, triangles or circles, then fried in hot oil until it puffs up. Baursak is served at almost every Kazakh table, the dastarkhan, with tea, butter, honey or jam, and it is piled high on plates at weddings and holidays. Many families keep a custom of frying baursak on Fridays and on memorial days, believing that the smell of fried bread reaches the spirits of the ancestors. A table without baursak hardly feels like a celebration.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Baursak can be square, triangular or round.
- It is usually served with tea at the dastarkhan, the festive table.
- Frying baursak on Fridays is a custom in many families.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

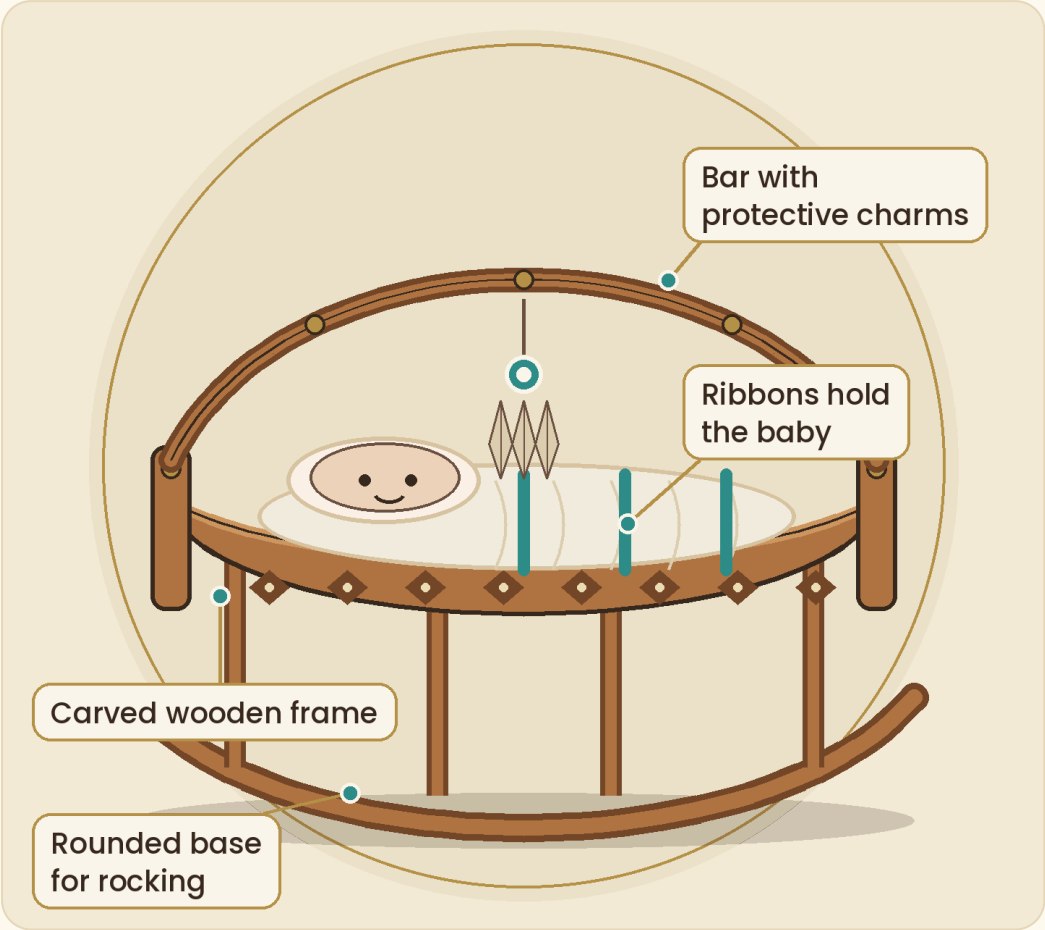
The meal is accompanied by **baursak**, *small round pieces of fried dough, served hot with tea.*

Scan to explore Baursak in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/baursak

Besik Бесік · *besík*

The cradle that welcomes a child



The besik is the traditional wooden cradle of Kazakh families. Made from light wood such as birch, pine or willow, it was easy to carry when a family moved between pastures. Its rounded base lets it rock gently, and the baby is wrapped and secured with soft ribbons. A small opening with a drain tube kept the cradle hygienic. Many besiks are carved and decorated, and protective charms were often attached to guard the child. A besik could be inherited within the family, and the besik toi, a celebration for placing a baby in the cradle for the first time, welcomes a new life.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Besiks are traditionally made from light woods such as birch, pine or willow.
- Protective charms were often attached to the cradle.
- The besik toi is a celebration held when a baby is first placed in the cradle.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

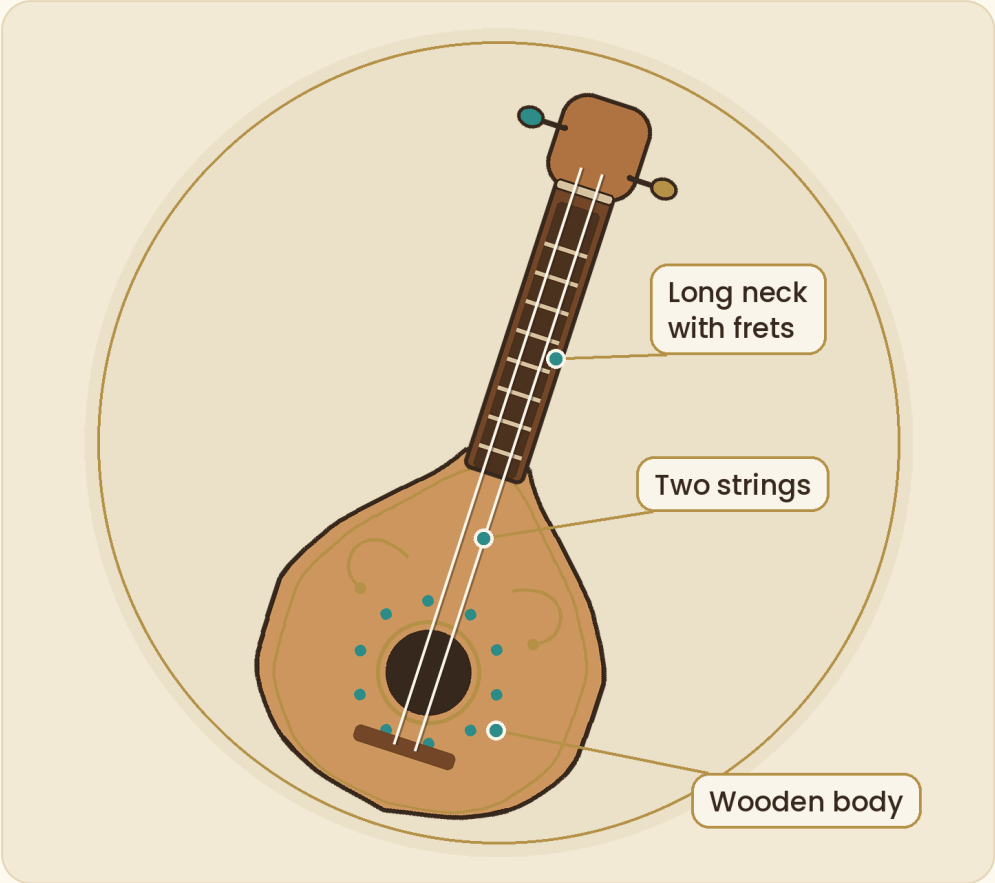
A newborn baby sleeps in a wooden **besik**, *and relatives gather for a small celebration when the baby is first laid in it.*

Scan to explore Besik in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/besik

Dombyra Домбыра · *dombıra*

The two-string voice of the steppe



The dombyra is the best-loved instrument of the Kazakh people. Its small wooden body is attached to a long, slender neck, and two strings stretch along its length. Players strum or strike the strings with the right hand in quick, rhythmic patterns, while the left hand presses them against the frets to shape the melody. The dombyra accompanies the songs of the akyns, the traditional poet-singers, and carries the kui, short instrumental pieces that tell stories of nature, history and feeling. For generations it has been a companion at feasts, gatherings and quiet evenings, and a living voice of Kazakh memory.

GOOD TO KNOW

- A kui is a short instrumental composition, often inspired by a legend, a landscape or an event.
- Akyns are poet-singers who improvise verse, often accompanied by the dombyra.
- In Kazakh families the dombyra is traditionally treated with great respect.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

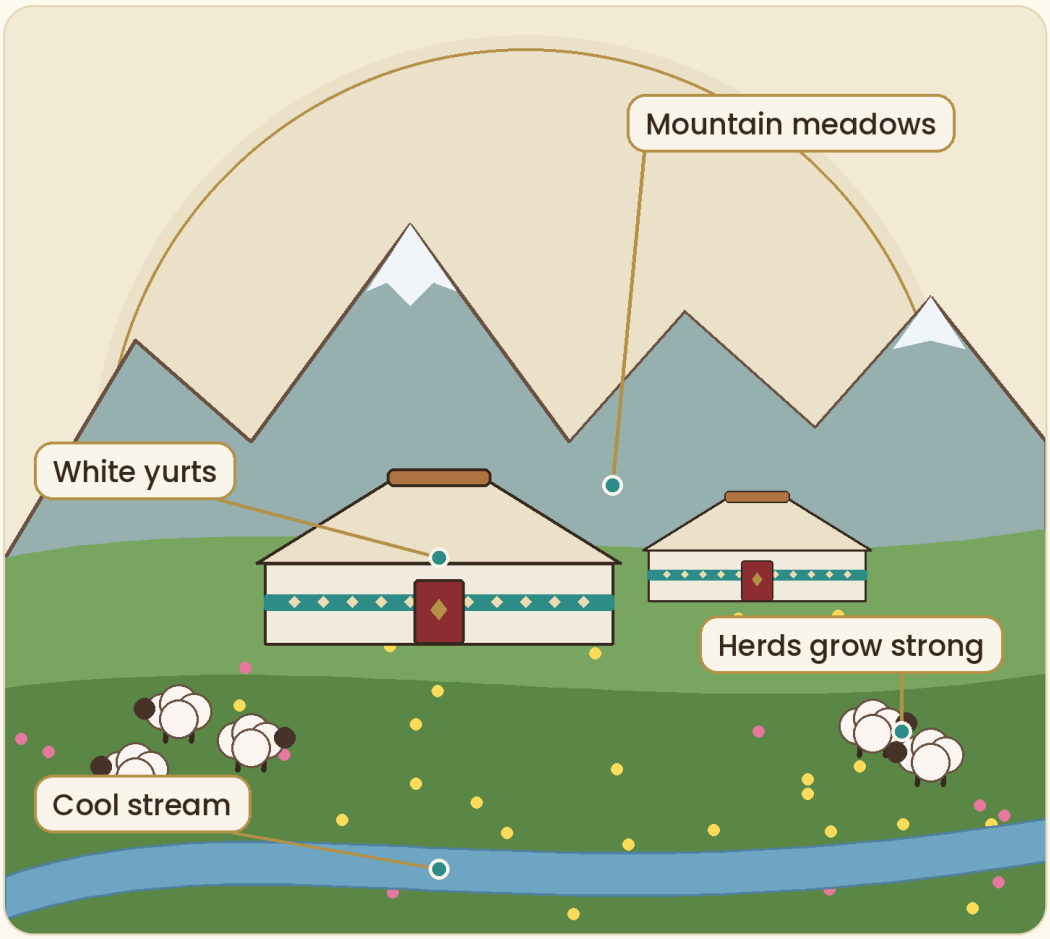
At the end of the meal you may sit and have tea while the musicians tune up the **dombra**, *a two-stringed instrument, and sing songs about love and war.*

Scan to explore Dombyra in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/dombra

Zhailau Жайлау · *zhaylau*

The green summer pasture



The zhailau is the summer pasture. In late spring, nomadic families left their winter quarters and moved with their herds to cool mountain meadows or green river valleys, where the grass was rich and water was plentiful. There they raised their white yurts, and the animals grew strong over the summer. Life on the zhailau was the happiest time of the year: mares gave plenty of milk for kymyz, young people met at gatherings, and weddings, horse races and games were held. Songs and poems praise the beauty of the zhailau, with its flowers, springs and wide skies.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Families moved to the zhailau in late spring and returned in autumn.
- Summer on the zhailau was the season of kymyz, weddings and festivals.
- Mountain meadows and river valleys made the best summer pastures.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

In summer the herders move their yurts to the **zhailau**, *the cool mountain pasture, where the animals feed on fresh grass.*

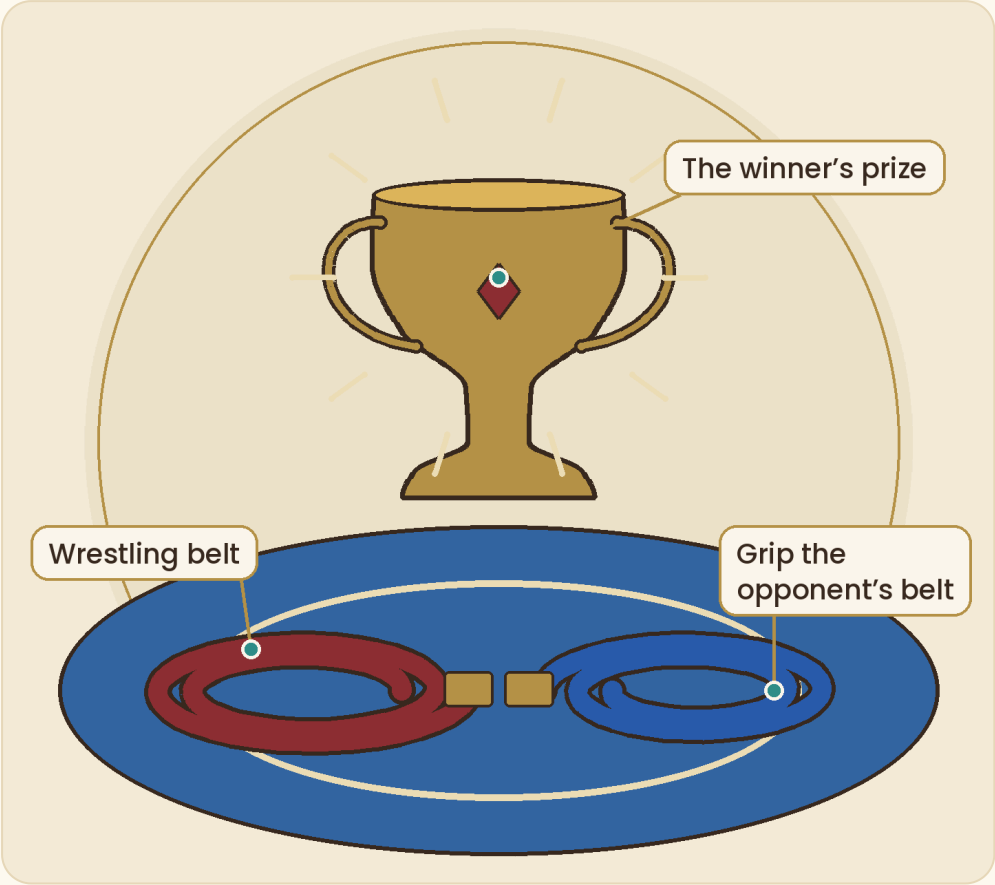
Scan to explore Zhailau in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/zhailau

Kazakh Kuresi

Қазақ күресі · *qazaq küresí*

The wrestling of the steppe



Kazakh kuresi is the national form of wrestling. Two wrestlers, called paluans, take hold of each other's belts and try to throw the opponent onto his back using strength, balance and clever technique. In the past, wrestling matches were held at every great toi and festival, and the winner received a valuable prize such as a horse or a camel. A paluan was respected not only for his strength but also for his honour and fairness. The legendary Kazhymukan Munaitpasov, who became a world champion in the early twentieth century, is a hero of Kazakh wrestling. Today the tournament "Kazakhstan Barysy" crowns the strongest wrestler of the country.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Kazakh wrestlers are called paluans.
- In traditional matches, wrestlers grip each other's belts.
- Kazhymukan Munaitpasov is the most famous Kazakh wrestler of the past.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

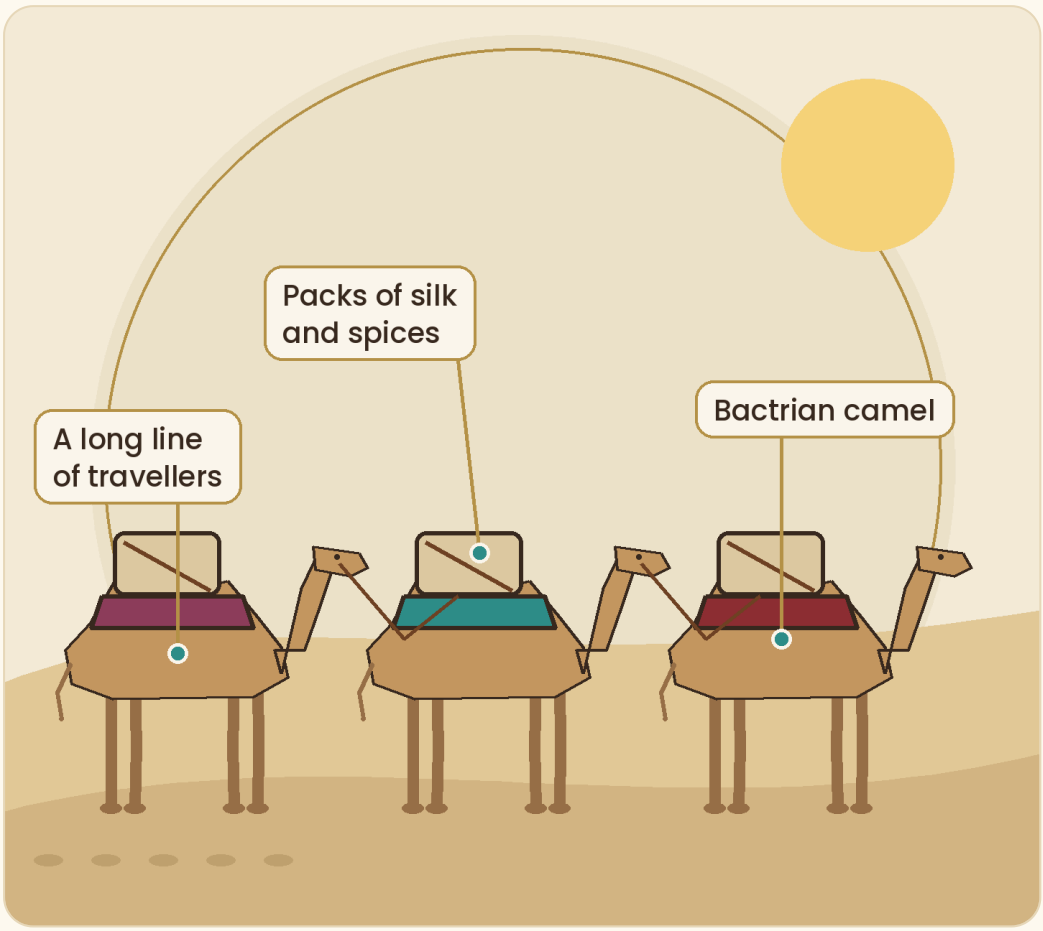
At a holiday, wrestlers meet in **Kazakh kuresi** *inside a ring of spectators and try to throw each other to the ground.*

Scan to explore Kazakh Kuresi in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/kazakh-kuresi

Keruen Керуен · *keruen*

The camel caravan of the Silk Road



A keruen is a caravan: a long line of camels, horses and people travelling together across the steppe and the desert. For centuries caravans followed the routes of the Great Silk Road through the land of present-day Kazakhstan, carrying silk, spices, cloth, metalwork and news between East and West. Two-humped Bactrian camels were ideal for this journey, because they can carry heavy loads and go a long time without water. Caravans stopped at wells and at caravanserais, roadside inns where travellers and animals rested. Cities such as Taraz, Otrar and Turkestan grew rich on the caravan trade.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The Great Silk Road crossed the south of present-day Kazakhstan.
- Bactrian camels can carry heavy loads and go a long time without water.
- A caravanserai was a roadside inn for caravans.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

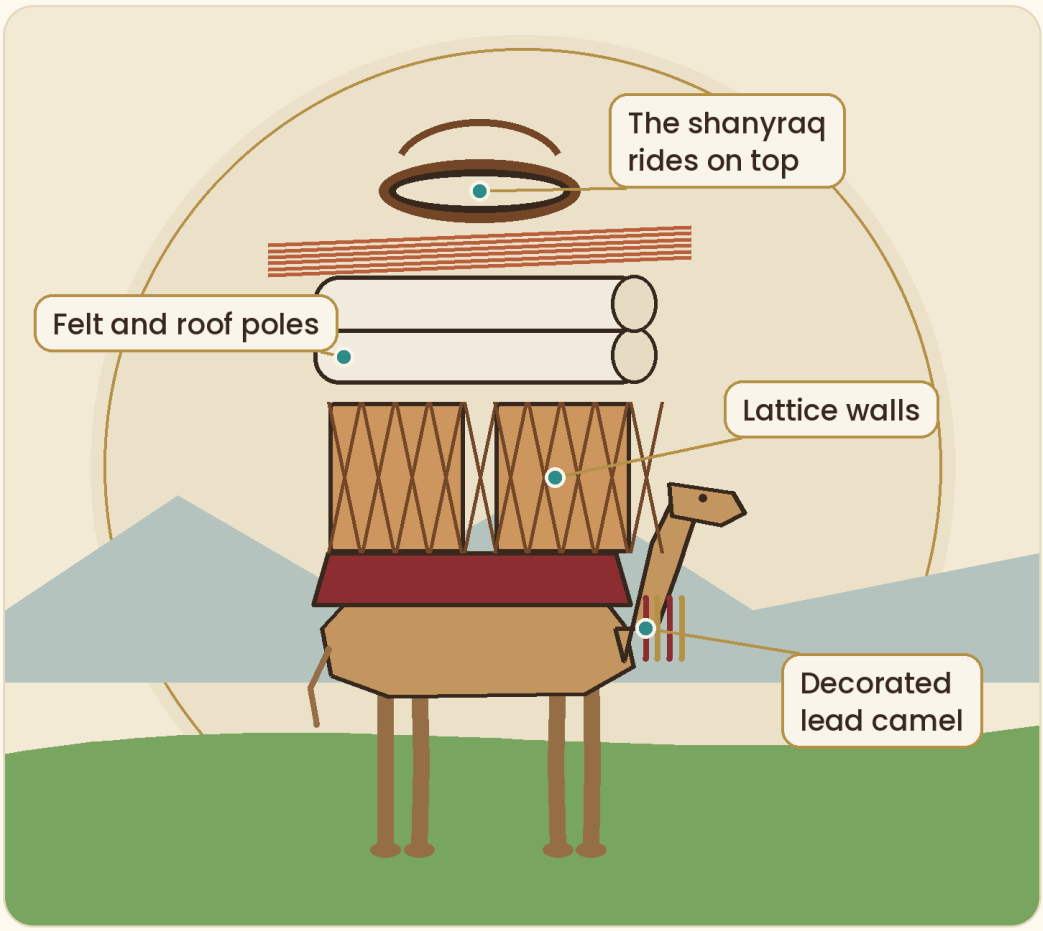
A long **keruen** *of camels crossed the steppe, carrying goods between distant towns.*

Scan to explore Keruen in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/keruen

Kosh Көш · *kösh*

The great seasonal move



Kosh is the move of a nomadic family or a whole aul, a village of yurts, from one pasture to the next. Several times a year, as the seasons changed, the yurts were taken down, and the felt, the lattice walls, the roof poles and the shanyraq were tied onto camels and horses together with chests, carpets and household goods. The kosh moved slowly across the steppe, with the herds walking alongside. A kosh was carefully organised and even beautiful: the leading camel was often decorated, and women and children rode in their best clothes. When the kosh arrived, the yurts were raised again within hours.

GOOD TO KNOW

- An aul is a village of yurts that moved together.
- A dismantled yurt could be carried by one or two camels.
- The leading camel of a kosh was often decorated with carpets and tassels.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

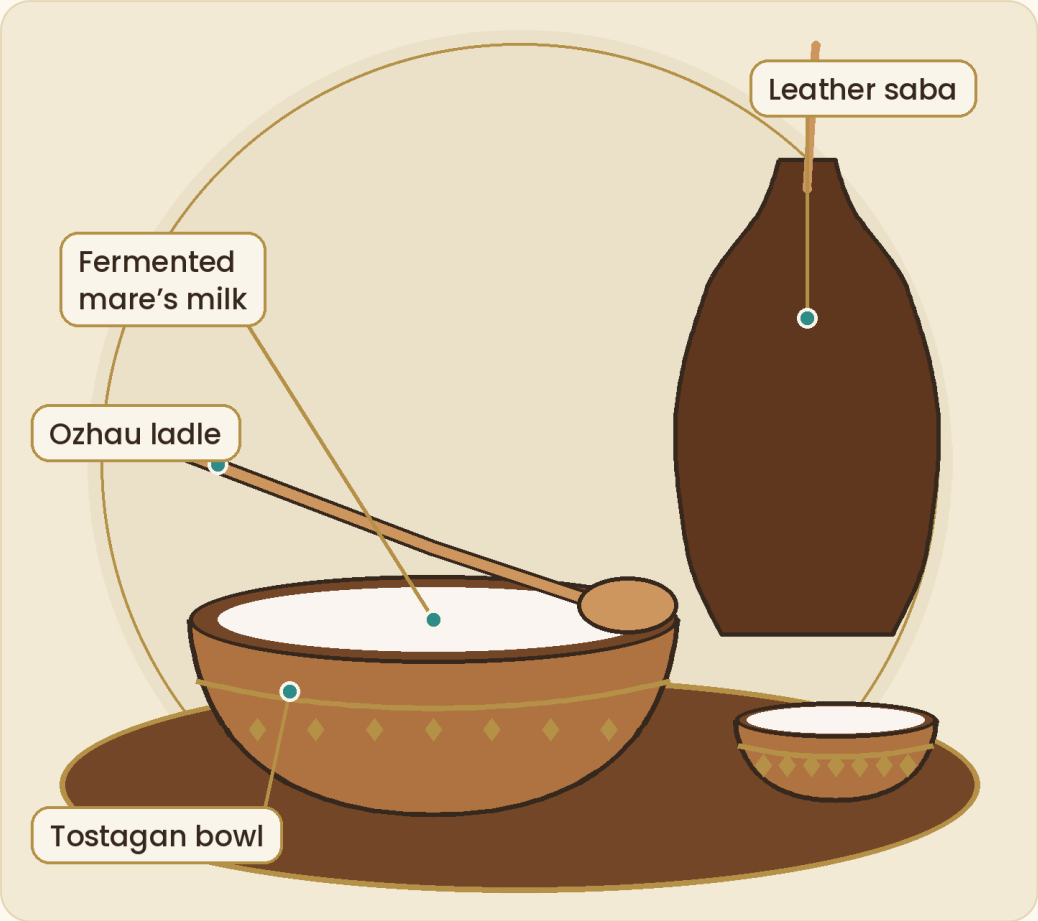
When autumn came, the whole village joined the **kosh**, *loading the yurts and moving to the winter pastures.*

Scan to explore Kosh in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/kosh

Kymyz Қымыз · *qımız*

The fermented mare's milk



Kymyz is fermented mare's milk, the most treasured drink of the Kazakh steppe. Mares are milked several times a day in summer, and the fresh milk is poured into a saba, a large leather vessel, where it is stirred again and again with a wooden plunger called a pispek. Over time the milk ferments and becomes slightly fizzy, sour and refreshing. Kymyz is served in wooden bowls, the tostagan, with a ladle called an ozhau. It is offered to guests as a sign of honour and is valued as a healthy drink. In spring, the first kymyz of the year is celebrated with a feast called kymyzmuryndyk.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Kymyz is made in a leather vessel called a saba.
- It is served in a wooden bowl, the tostagan, with a ladle, the ozhau.
- Kymyzmuryndyk is the spring feast of the first kymyz.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

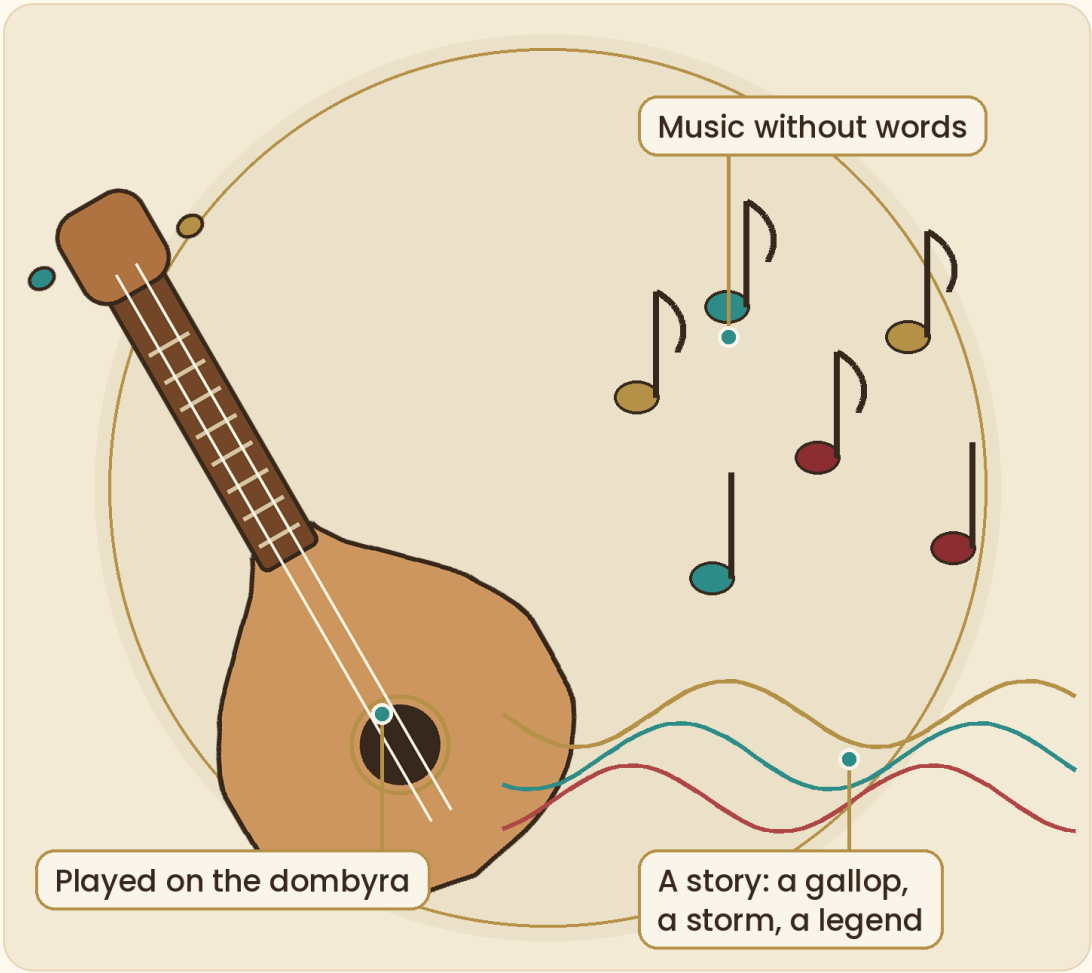
Guests in the yurt are offered a bowl of **kymyz**, *the sour mare's milk drink, as a sign of hospitality.*

Scan to explore Kymyz in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/kymyz

Kui Күй · küy

A story told without words



A kui is a piece of instrumental music, most often played on the dombyra, and also on the kobyz and the sybyzgy flute. A kui has no words, but it tells a story: the gallop of horses, a storm on the steppe, the sorrow of a lost loved one or a historic event. Before playing, a musician often tells the legend behind the kui, and then the instrument continues the story. Composers of kui are called kuishi. The greatest of them, Kurmangazy, wrote famous kuis such as "Sary-Arka" and "Adai", and Dina Nurpeisova and Tattimbet are also loved. Kui is the heart of Kazakh instrumental music.

GOOD TO KNOW

- A kui is purely instrumental and has no sung words.
- Composers and performers of kui are called kuishi.
- Kurmangazy's kui "Sary-Arka" is one of the best-known Kazakh melodies.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

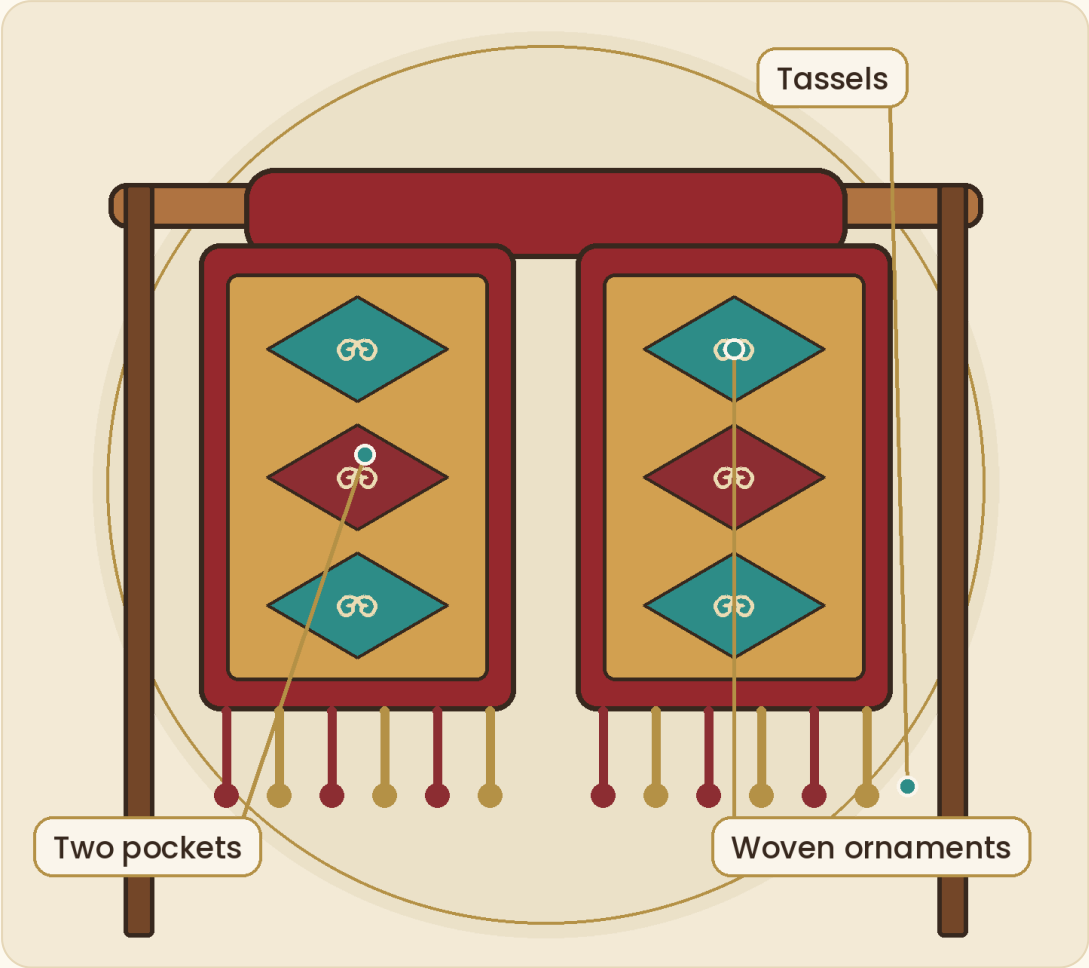
Around the fire the musician plays a **kui** *on the dombra, a melody that tells a story without any words.*

Scan to explore Kui in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/kui

Qorzhyn Қоржын · *qorzhın*

The double saddlebag



A qorzhyn is a double bag made of two pockets joined by a band. It is thrown over the back of a horse or a camel, with one pocket hanging on each side, so that the load stays balanced. Qorzhyns were woven or sewn from wool, felt and leather and decorated with bright geometric ornaments and tassels. Travellers carried food, clothes and gifts in them, and at home a qorzhyn hung on the wall of the yurt as a storage bag. A beautifully made qorzhyn showed the skill of the women who wove it and was often part of a bride's dowry.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The two pockets hang on each side of the saddle, keeping the load balanced.
- Qorzhyns are decorated with woven ornaments and tassels.
- In the yurt, a qorzhyn was hung on the wall for storage.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

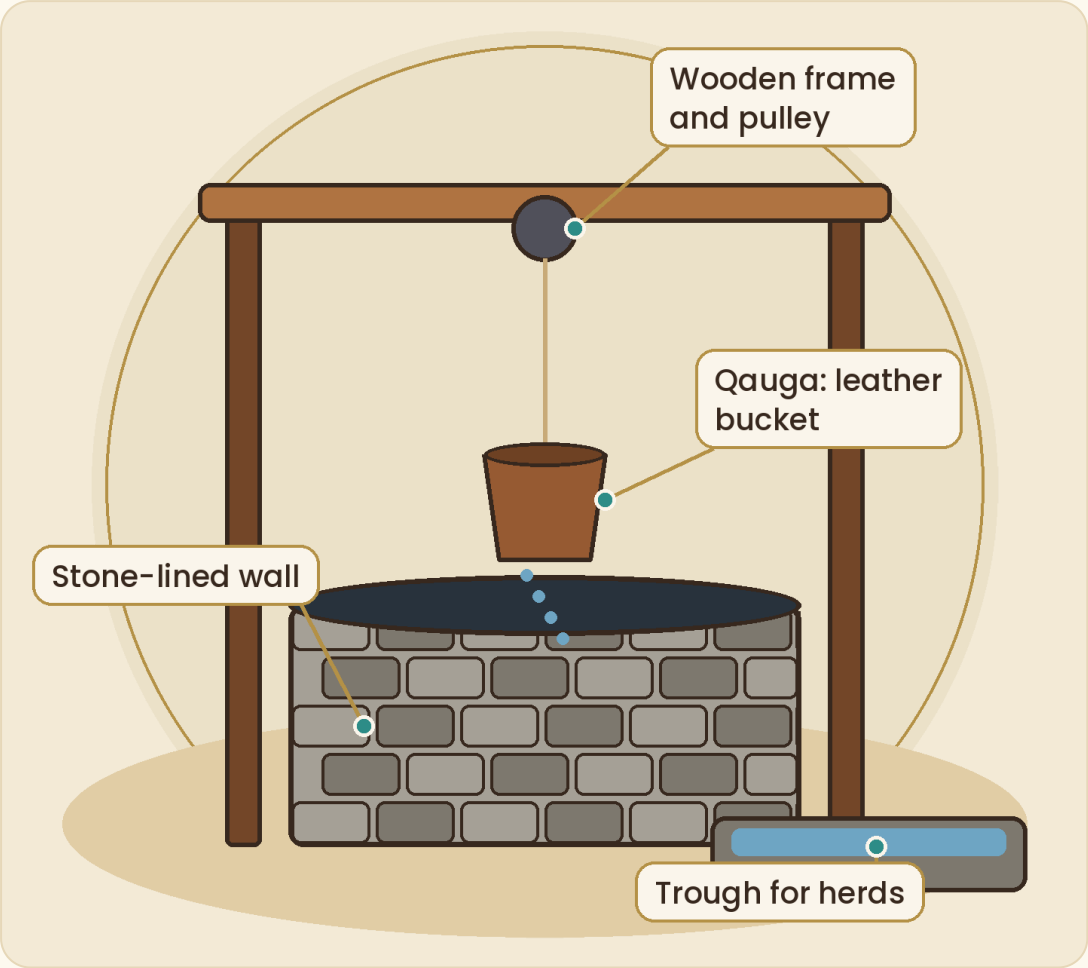
Before the journey, the rider hangs a pair of **qorzhyn** *over the saddle, packed with bread and clothes.*

Scan to explore Qorzhyn in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/qorzhyn

Qudyq Құдық · *quduq*

The well that gives life



A qudyq is a well. On the dry steppe and in the desert, wells were a matter of life: without water, neither people nor herds could survive, and caravan and migration routes followed the line of the wells. Well-diggers were skilled and respected masters who knew where to find water underground. The walls were lined with stones or wood, and water was raised with a leather bucket called a qauga on a rope, sometimes pulled up by a camel or a horse. To dig a well for others was considered a great good deed, and many wells carry the name of the person who dug them.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Migration and caravan routes followed the line of wells.
- Water was raised in a leather bucket called a qauga.
- Digging a well for others was considered a great good deed.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

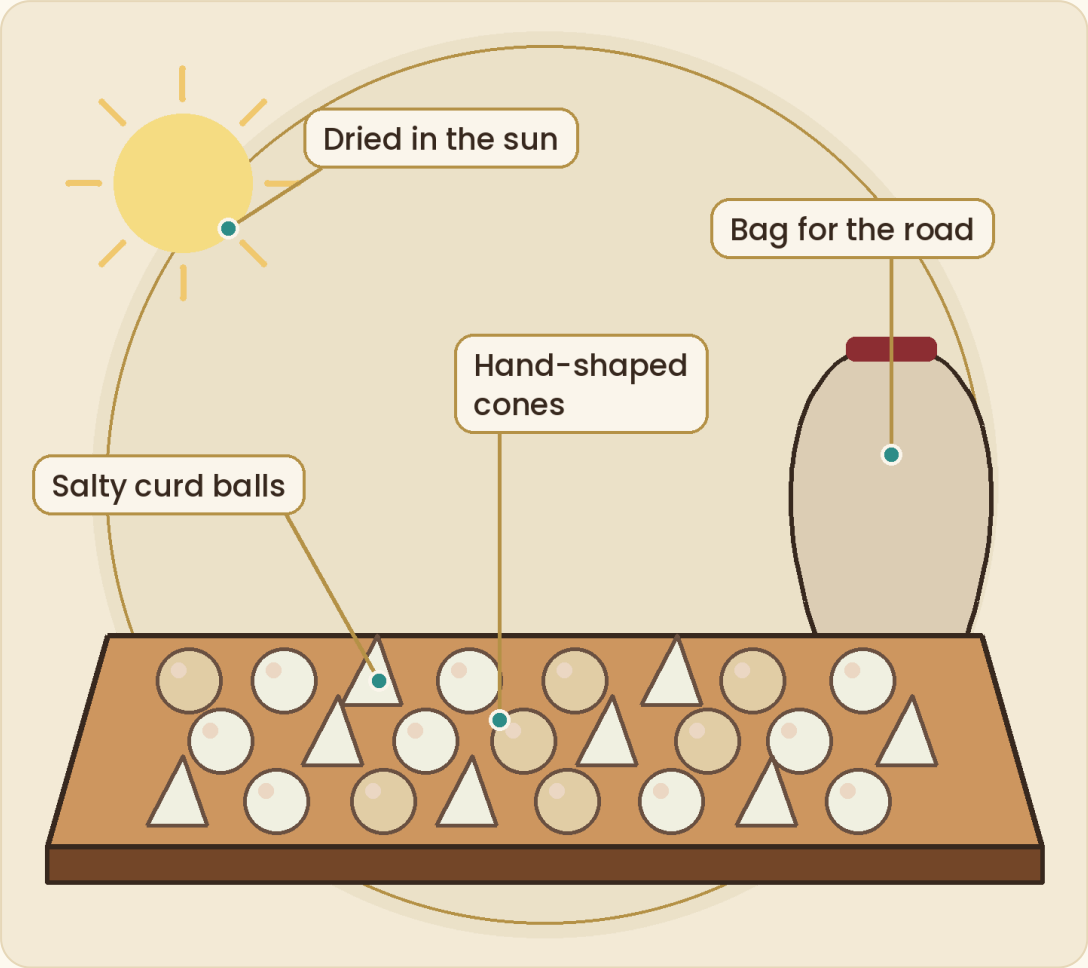
After days of travel, the caravan stops at a **qudyq**, *a well, to give water to the animals.*

Scan to explore Qudyq in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/qudyq

Qurt Құрт · *qurt*

The dried cheese of the road



Qurt is a dried dairy food. Sour milk or ayran is boiled and strained through a cloth until a thick curd is left. The curd is salted, shaped by hand into small balls or rolls, and laid out in the sun and wind to dry until it is hard as stone. Qurt keeps for many months without spoiling, so nomads always had it on long journeys and through the winter. It is eaten as a snack, sucked slowly, or soaked and crushed into soups and drinks. Its taste is salty and sour. Today qurt is sold in every market of Kazakhstan, in white, smoked and flavoured varieties.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Qurt is made from strained, salted curd that is dried in the sun.
- It keeps for months, which made it ideal food for travellers.
- Qurt can be eaten as it is or dissolved in water for soups and drinks.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

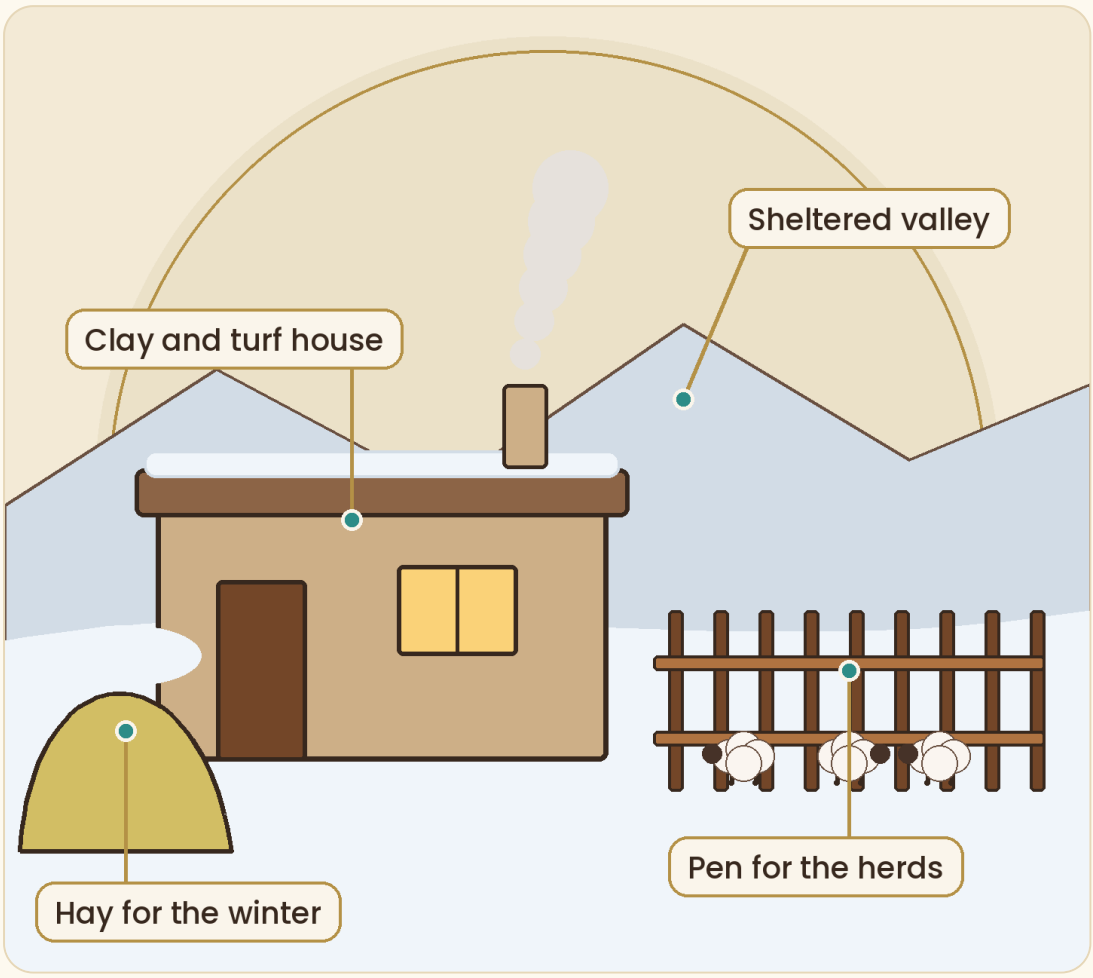
Before a long journey, the nomads put **qurt**, *dried salty cheese balls, into their bags.*

Scan to explore Qurt in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/qurt

Qystau Қыстау · *qıstau*

The sheltered winter home



The qystau is the winter quarters of a nomadic family. In late autumn, families returned from the summer pastures to a sheltered place, a valley, the foot of a hill or a riverbank with reeds, where the snow was shallower and the wind weaker. Here they often had permanent buildings of stone, clay or turf, along with pens and sheds that protected the animals from frost and wolves. Hay was cut in summer and stored for the winter. The qystau was used year after year and belonged to the same family for generations, so it was a place of deep attachment and memory.

GOOD TO KNOW

- A qystau was chosen in a place protected from wind and deep snow.
- Winter buildings were made of stone, clay, turf or wood.
- The same family used its qystau year after year.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

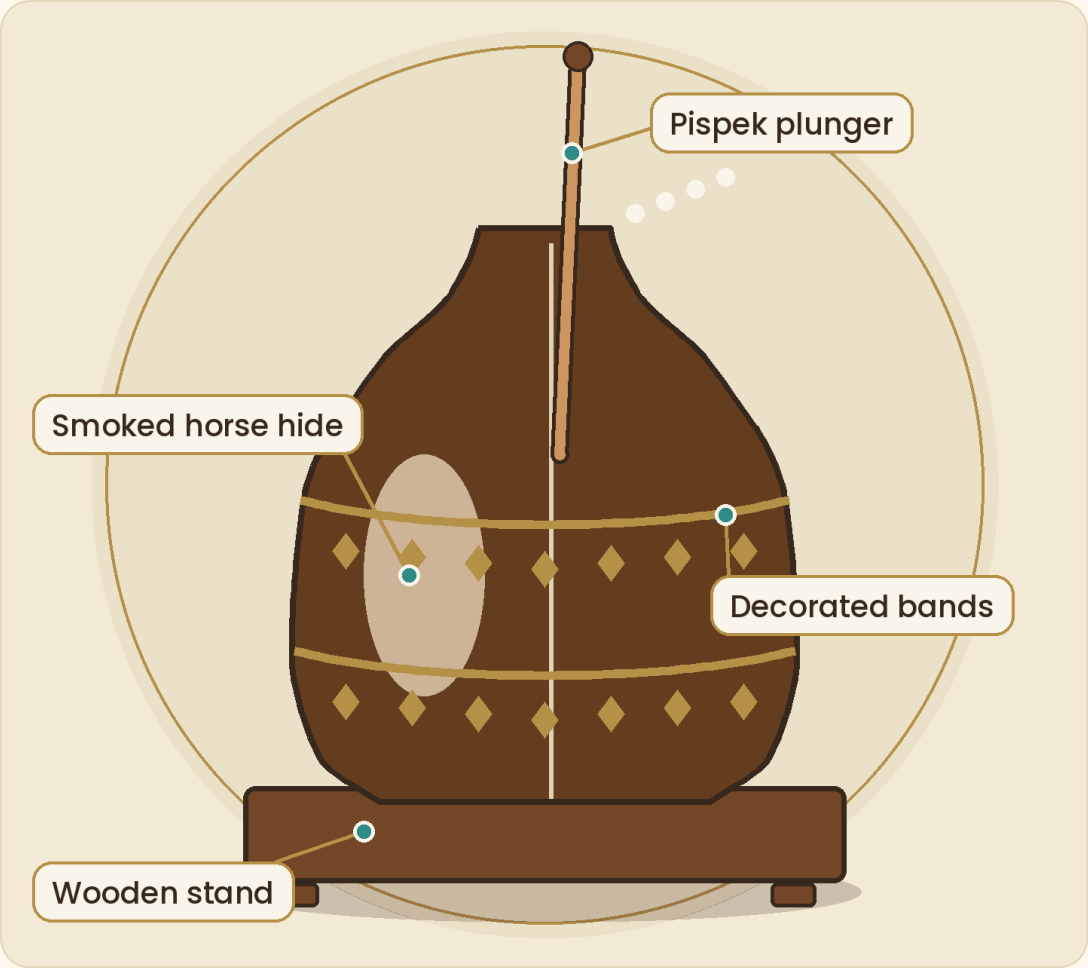
When the snow arrives, the family moves into the **qystau**, *a winter dwelling sheltered from the wind.*

Scan to explore Qystau in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/qystau

Saba Саба · *saba*

The leather vessel for kymyz



A saba is a large vessel made of smoked horse hide, used for making and storing kymyz. Its wide body narrows into a neck, and it stands on a wooden base or hangs inside the yurt, to the right of the entrance. Fresh mare's milk is poured into the saba, and the family stirs it many times a day with the pispek, a long wooden plunger with a cross-piece at the end. Smoking the leather gives kymyz its special taste and keeps the vessel clean. A large saba could hold enough kymyz for many guests, and a full saba was a sign of wealth and hospitality.

GOOD TO KNOW

- A saba is made of smoked horse hide.
- The milk inside is stirred with a wooden plunger called a pispek.
- A full saba was a sign of a generous and wealthy home.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

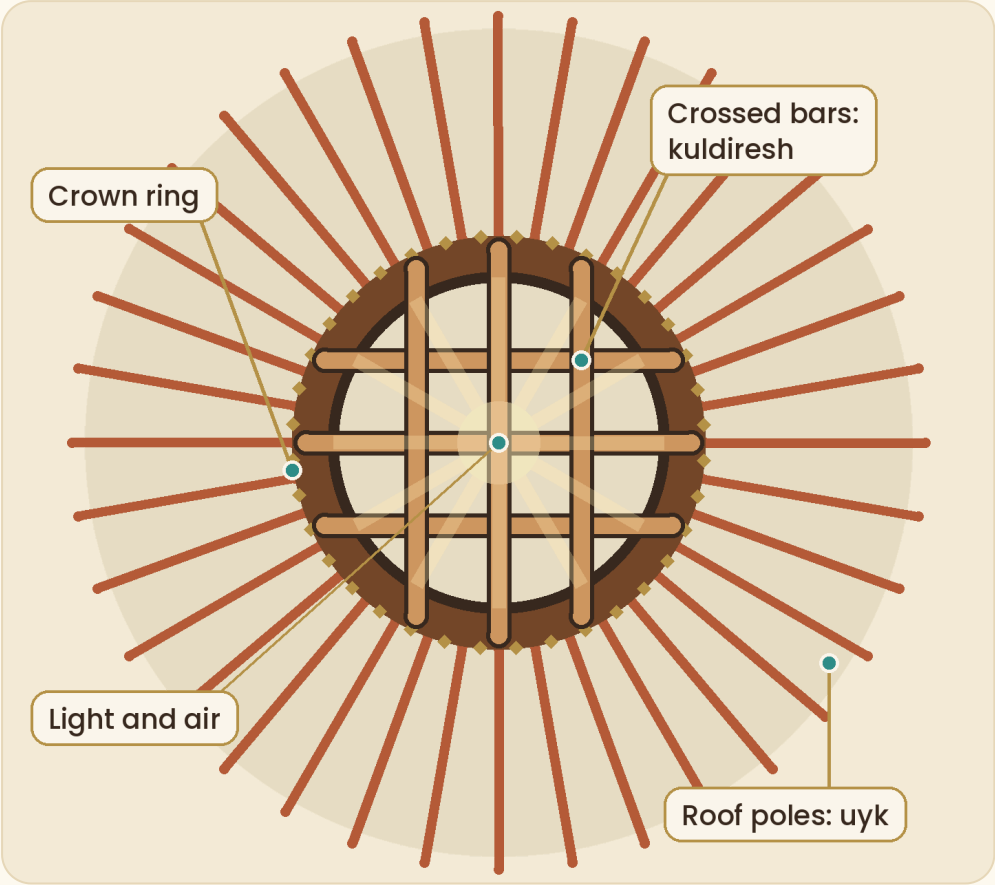
A leather **saba** *hangs by the door of the yurt, and the housewife churns it to prepare kymyz.*

Scan to explore Saba in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/saba

Shanyraq Шаңырақ · *shañıraq*

The crown of the yurt



The shanyraq is the wooden crown ring at the top of the yurt. The curved roof poles rest against it, and its crossed bars, the kuldiresh, form a dome in the middle. Through the opening of the shanyraq, light falls into the yurt and smoke from the hearth rises out, and at night the family could see the stars. The shanyraq is more than a part of the house: it is the symbol of the family and the home. It is passed down from generation to generation, traditionally kept by the youngest son in the parents' home. Today the shanyraq appears on the coat of arms of Kazakhstan as a symbol of a shared home for all its people.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The crossed bars inside the shanyraq are called kuldiresh.
- The family shanyraq is traditionally kept by the youngest son.
- The shanyraq is pictured at the centre of the coat of arms of Kazakhstan.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

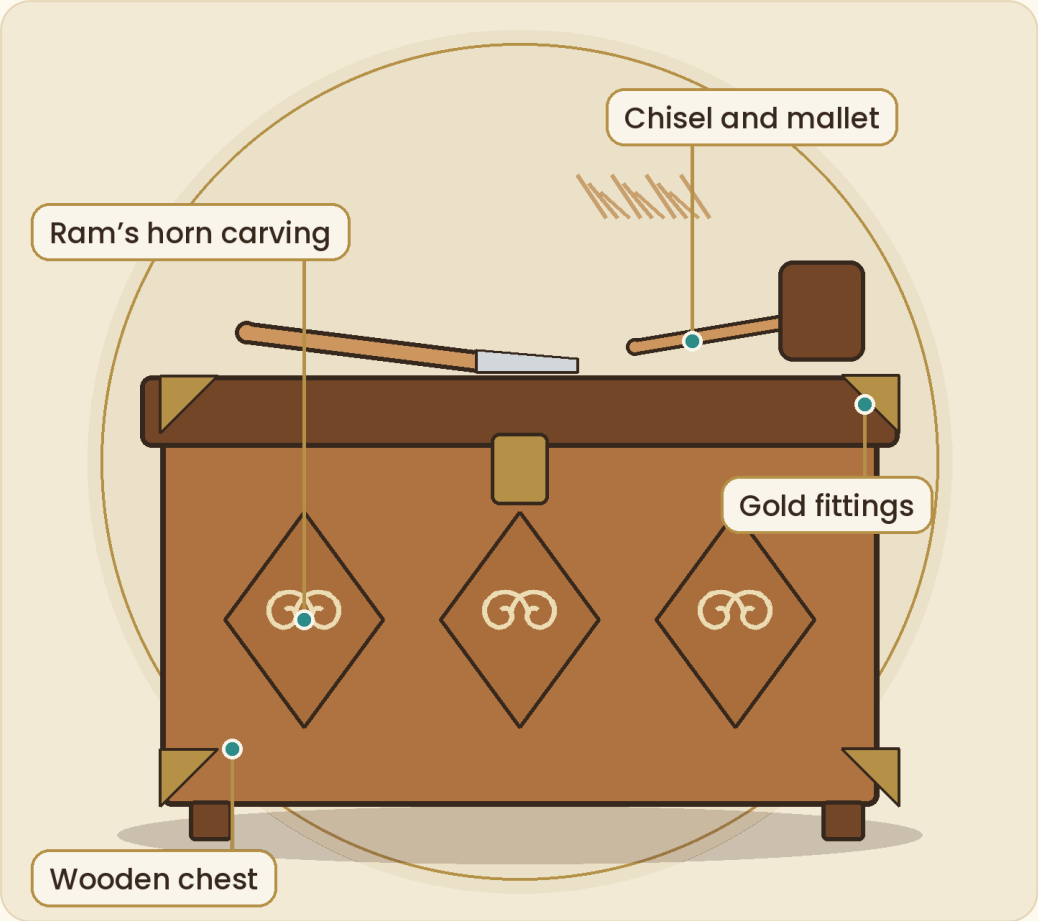
Looking up inside the yurt, you see the daylight pour through the **shanyraq**, *the crown ring that stands for the family home.*

Scan to explore Shanyraq in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/shanyraq

Sheber Шебер · *sheber*

The master craftsman



A sheber is a master craftsman, a person with "golden hands". On the steppe, almost everything a family needed was made by hand: yurts and their wooden frames, cradles, chests, saddles, bowls, felt carpets, leather vessels and clothing. Shebers carved wood, pressed felt, tanned leather and embroidered patterns, and they decorated their work with traditional ornaments such as the ram's horn, the qoshqar muiiz. Their skill was passed from master to apprentice and from parents to children. A sheber was greatly respected, because their work combined usefulness with beauty. Today Kazakh shebers keep these crafts alive in workshops and festivals.

GOOD TO KNOW

- A sheber can work with wood, felt, leather, textiles or metal.
- The ram's horn pattern, qoshqar muiiz, is one of the most common ornaments.
- Crafts were taught from master to apprentice.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

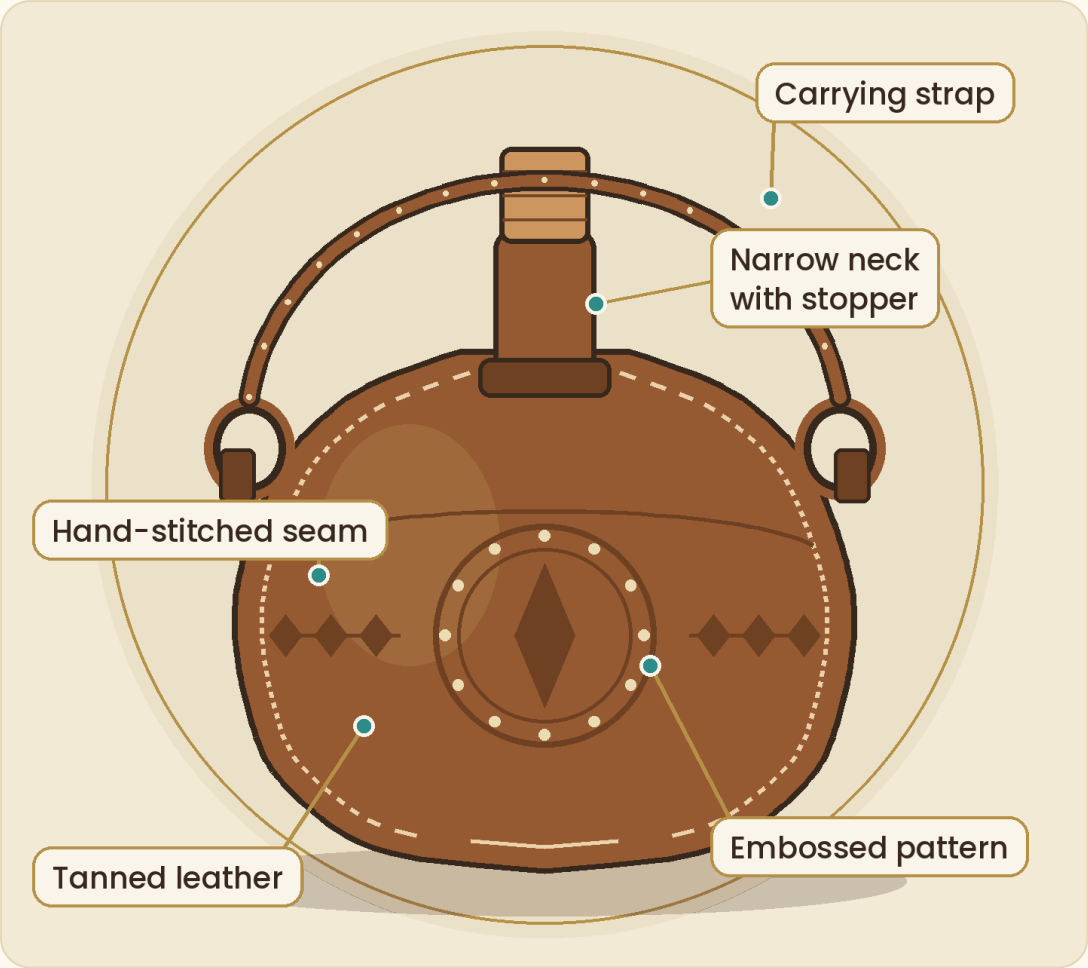
A **sheber** *spent weeks carving the wooden frame of a yurt, and his work was known across the steppe.*

Scan to explore Sheber in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/sheber

Torsyq Торсық · *torsıq*

The leather vessel of the road



The torsyq is a traditional leather vessel for carrying and storing drinks, especially kymyz, the fermented mare's milk beloved on the steppe. Craftsmen cut and sewed tanned hide into a rounded vessel with a narrow neck and handles, and often decorated it with embossed patterns. Light, durable and resistant to knocks, the torsyq suited a life on the move, when a rider needed to carry drink over long distances. The leather also helped keep the drink cool. Today the torsyq reminds us how ingeniously nomadic families made everyday objects from the materials of their herds.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Kymyz is fermented mare's milk, a traditional drink of the steppe.
- Leather decoration included embossing with carved wooden plates.
- Leather vessels came in several shapes for different kinds of drink.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

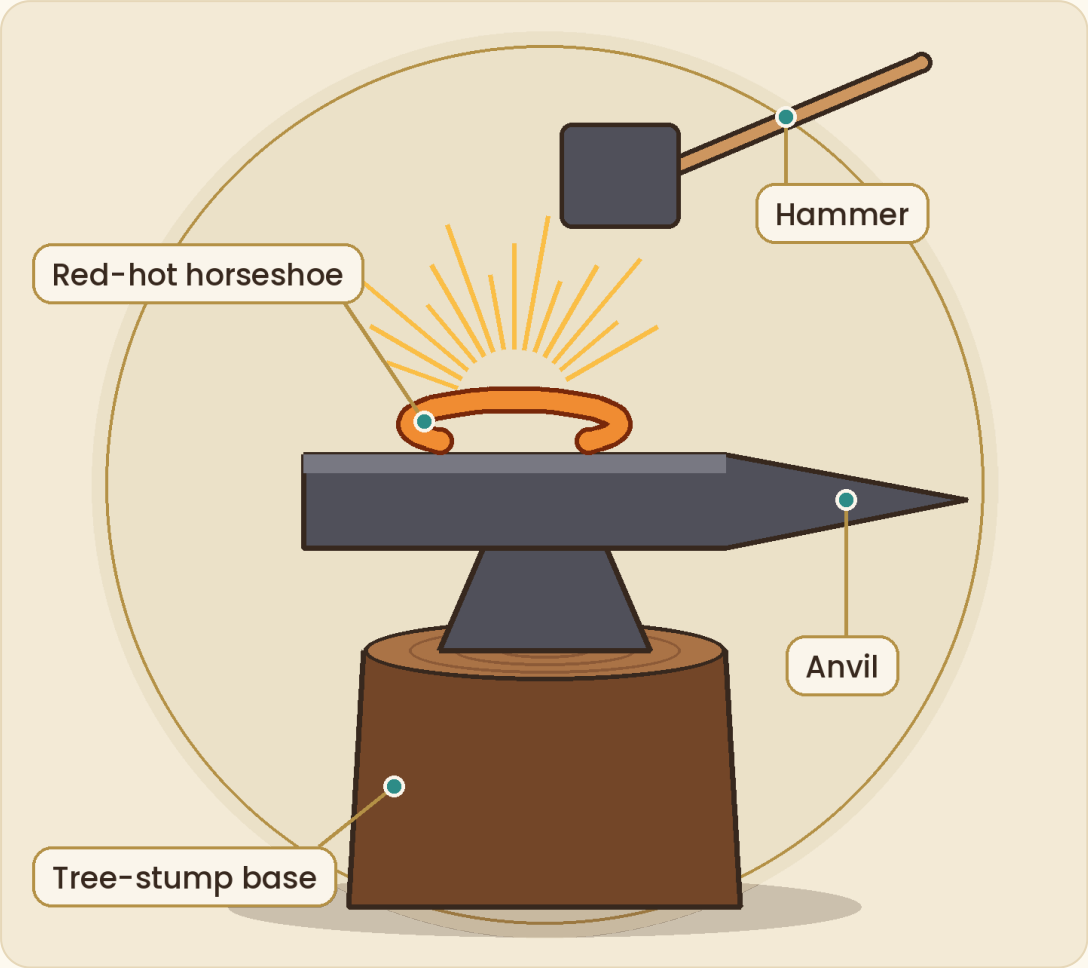
On the road, the horseman carries water in a leather **torsyq** *tied to his saddle.*

Scan to explore Torsyq in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/torsyk

Usta Ұста · *usta*

The blacksmith master



An usta is a master, and above all a blacksmith. At the forge, the usta heated iron until it glowed, then shaped it on the anvil with a hammer. He made horseshoes, bits and stirrups for horses, knives, axes, scissors, cauldron hooks, door hinges and the metal parts of carts and chests, and in the past also weapons for warriors. Every aul needed an usta, because life with horses and herds depended on strong metal tools. The usta was respected as a wise and hard-working person, and the craft was often handed down from father to son.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The usta worked at a forge with fire, bellows, hammer and anvil.
- He made horseshoes, stirrups, knives and many household tools.
- The craft was often passed down from father to son.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

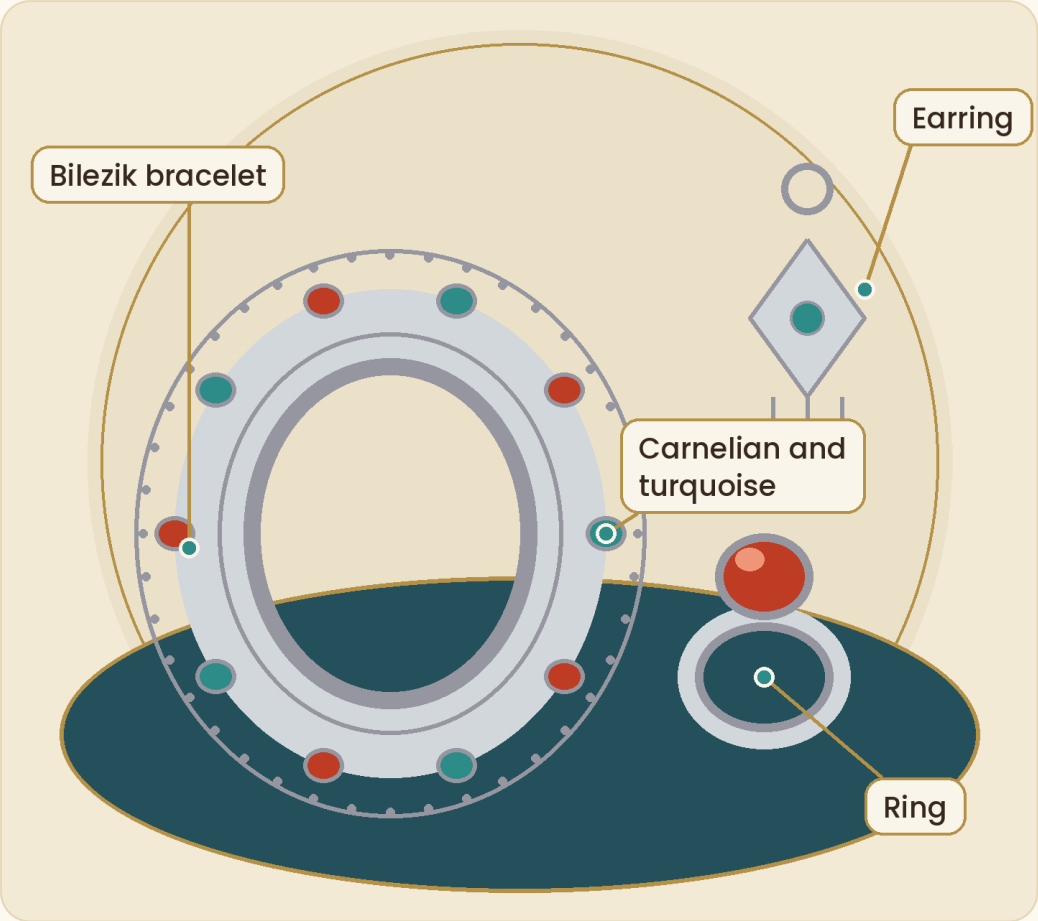
The village **usta** *heats the iron in the forge and hammers it into a horseshoe.*

Scan to explore Usta in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/usta

Zerger Зергер · *zerger*

The silver jeweller



A zerger is a jeweller, a master of silver and gold. Kazakh zergers made bracelets called bilezik, rings, earrings, hair pendants, buttons and decorations for belts, saddles and the bride's saukele. They used fine techniques such as filigree, made of thin twisted wire, granulation with tiny metal balls, engraving and blackening with niello, and they set stones such as carnelian, coral and turquoise. Silver was believed to protect its wearer, so jewellery was more than an ornament. Each piece was given at important moments of life, such as a wedding or the birth of a child, and many are kept as family treasures.

GOOD TO KNOW

- A bilezik is a bracelet; a zhuzik is a ring.
- Kazakh jewellers often set carnelian, coral and turquoise into silver.
- Silver jewellery was believed to protect the person who wore it.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

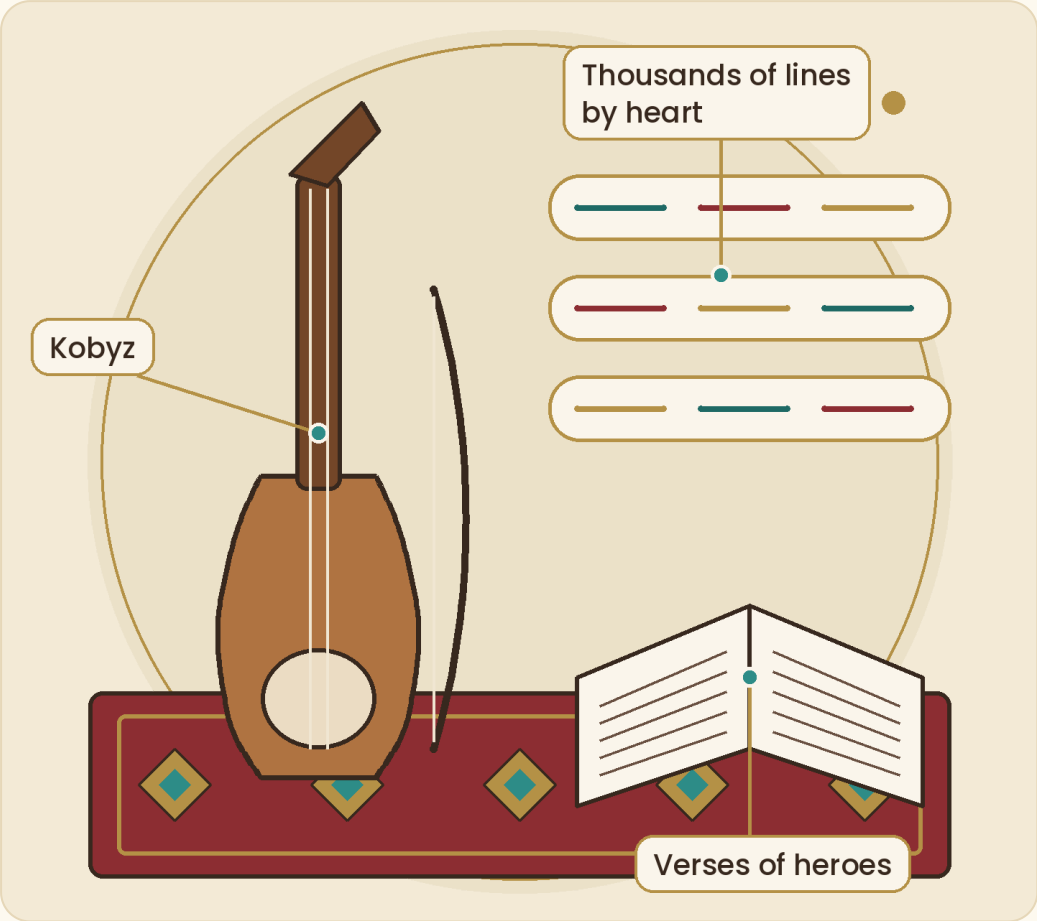
A **zerger** *works silver into earrings and bracelets for a bride.*

Scan to explore Zerger in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/zerger

Zhyr Жыр · *zhır*

The epic song of heroes



Zhyr is epic poetry: long poems that tell of heroes, battles, journeys and the history of the people, sung or recited to the dombyra or the kobyz. The performers of zhyr, the zhyraus, were poets, storytellers and wise advisers. They knew thousands of lines by heart and could also compose their own verse. Famous zhyraus such as Asan Kaigy, Bukhar Zhyrau and Umbetai Zhyrau spoke to khans and to the people about justice, unity and the meaning of life. Heroic epics such as "Koblandy Batyr" and "Er Targyn" were passed down through zhyr for centuries, keeping the memory of the past alive.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The singers of zhyr are called zhyraus.
- Zhyr is performed to the dombyra or the kobyz.
- "Koblandy Batyr" and "Er Targyn" are famous Kazakh heroic epics.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

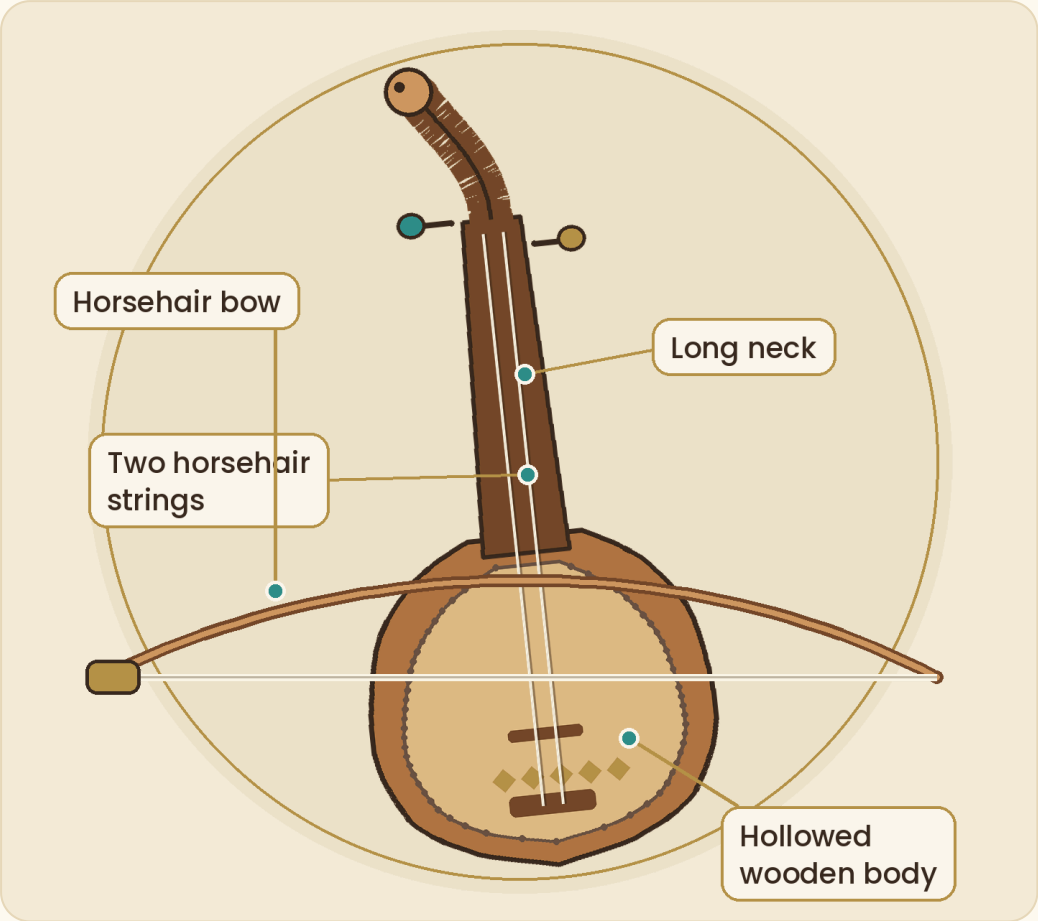
A **zhyr** *is sung by a zhyrau, who tells the history and wisdom of the people to the sound of the kobyz.*

Scan to explore Zhyr in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/zhyr

Kobyz Қобыз · qobız

The ancient bowed instrument



The kobyz is an ancient bowed instrument of the Kazakh steppe. Its body is hollowed from wood and joined to a long neck, and it carries two strings made of horsehair. A bow, also strung with horsehair, is drawn across the strings while the player holds the instrument upright. Its low, husky, haunting voice was long associated with the baqsy, healers and shamans who played to ease suffering and guide spirits. Today the kobyz is remembered through the legend of Korkyt Ata, the sage and musician of Turkic tradition, and its music is performed on concert stages, keeping an ancient sound alive.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The kobyz is a bowed instrument, unlike the plucked dombyra.
- Its strings and bow are traditionally made of horsehair.
- Korkyt Ata, a legendary sage, is closely associated with the kobyz in Turkic tradition.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

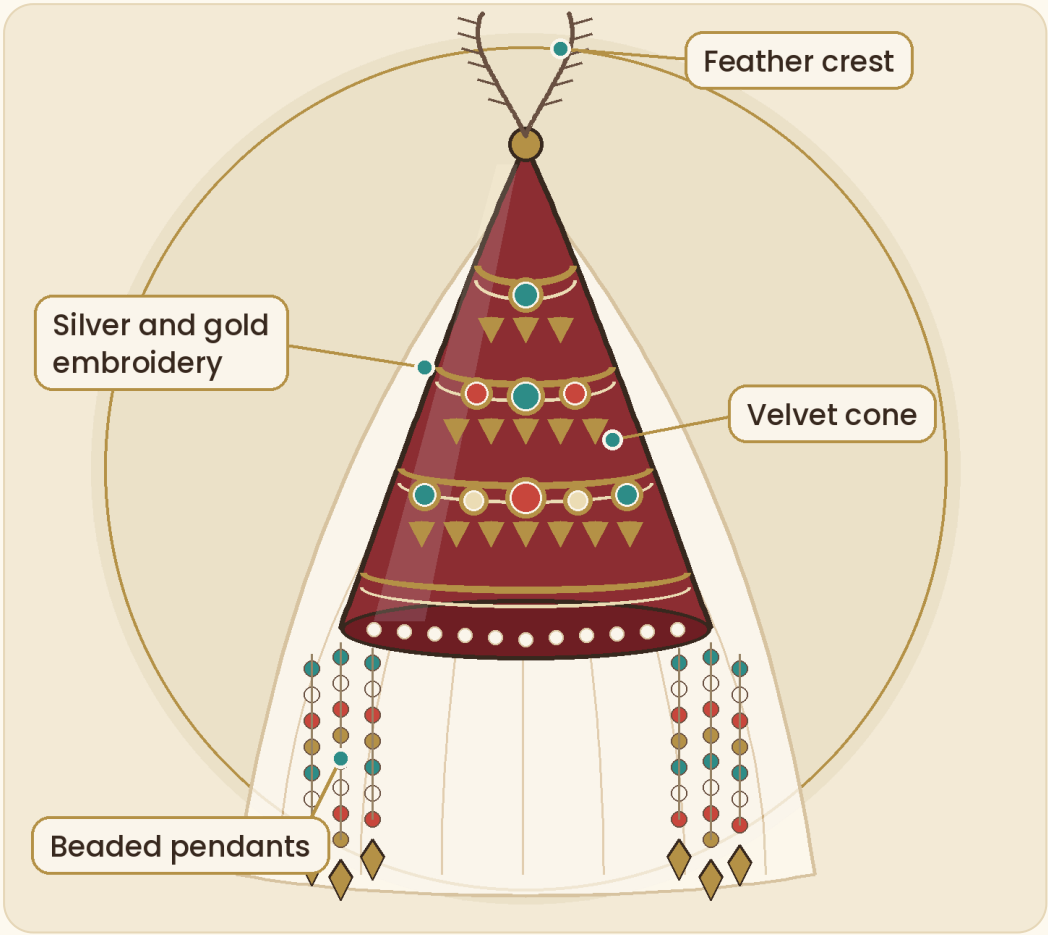
The musician draws a bow across the **kobyz**, *and its deep, haunting sound recalls the legends of the steppe.*

Scan to explore Kobyz in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/kobyz

Saukele Сәукеле · *säukele*

The bride's crowning headdress



The saukele is the tall, conical headdress worn by a Kazakh bride on her wedding day. Its firm cone is covered with fine fabric and decorated with silver and gilded ornaments, coral, pearls and semi-precious stones. Long strands of beads and pendants frame the face, and a veil may fall over the shoulders. Making a saukele took months of careful work by skilled craftswomen, and a fine one could be treasured and passed down within a family. Beyond its beauty, the saukele expressed the status of the family and the good wishes of relatives for the happiness of the young bride.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The saukele is worn at weddings and is one of the most elaborate pieces of Kazakh traditional dress.
- Silver, coral, pearls and semiprecious stones are common decorative materials.
- Fine examples were valued as family heirlooms.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

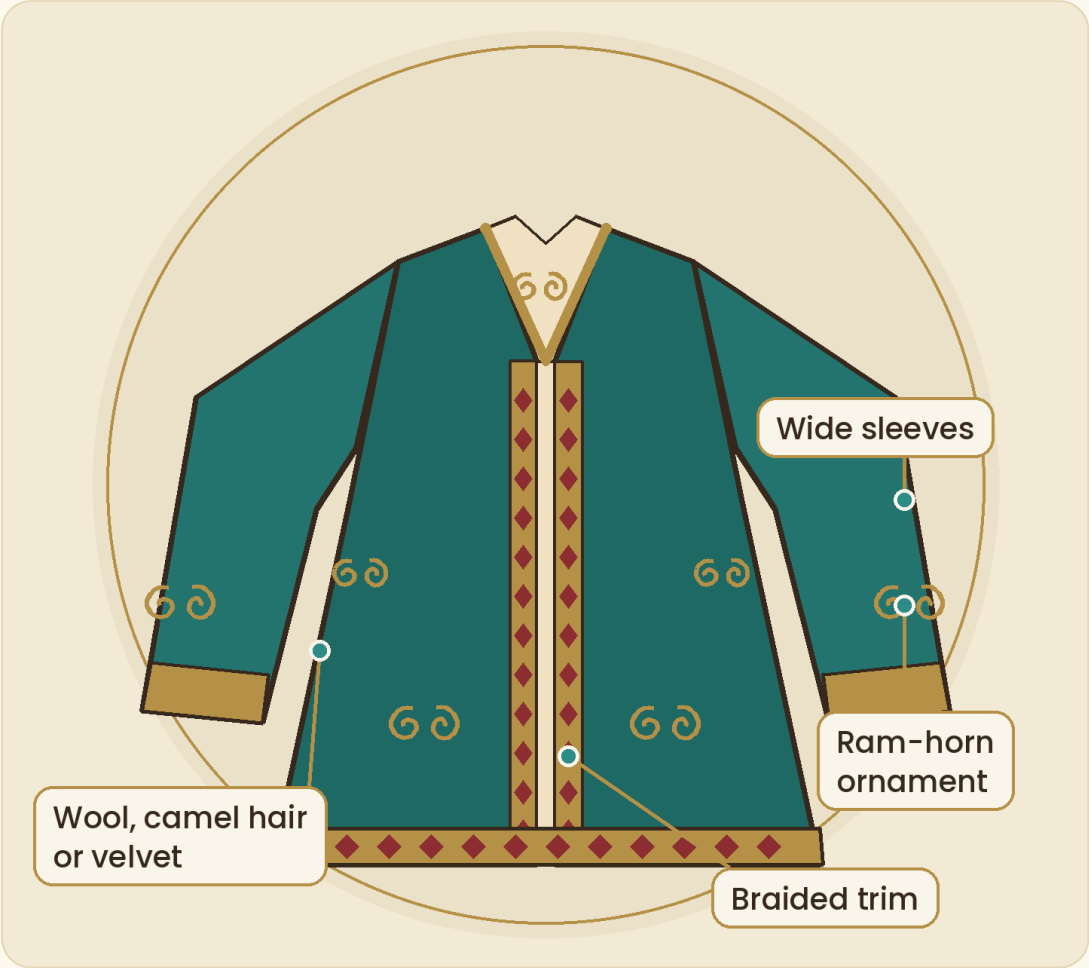
The bride puts on a multi-layered white gown and a tall **saukele** *with a long veil. When the veil falls behind her head, she has "opened her face" and the wedding ceremony is complete.*

Scan to explore Saukele in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/saukele

Shapan Шапан · *shapan*

The robe of respect and welcome



The shapan is the traditional Kazakh long outer robe, worn by both men and women. Made from wool, camel hair or heavy cotton and often lined, it protects against wind and cold on the open steppe. Festive versions are cut from velvet or silk and richly decorated with embroidery and braided trim along the edges. Presenting a shapan is a gesture of deep respect: it is traditionally offered to honoured guests, to a groom, or to an elder, and being given one is a sign of welcome and honour. Today the shapan still appears at celebrations and ceremonies.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The shapan was worn by both men and women in different styles.
- Placing a shapan on a guest's shoulders is a traditional gesture of honour.
- Festive shapans were embroidered or trimmed with braid.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

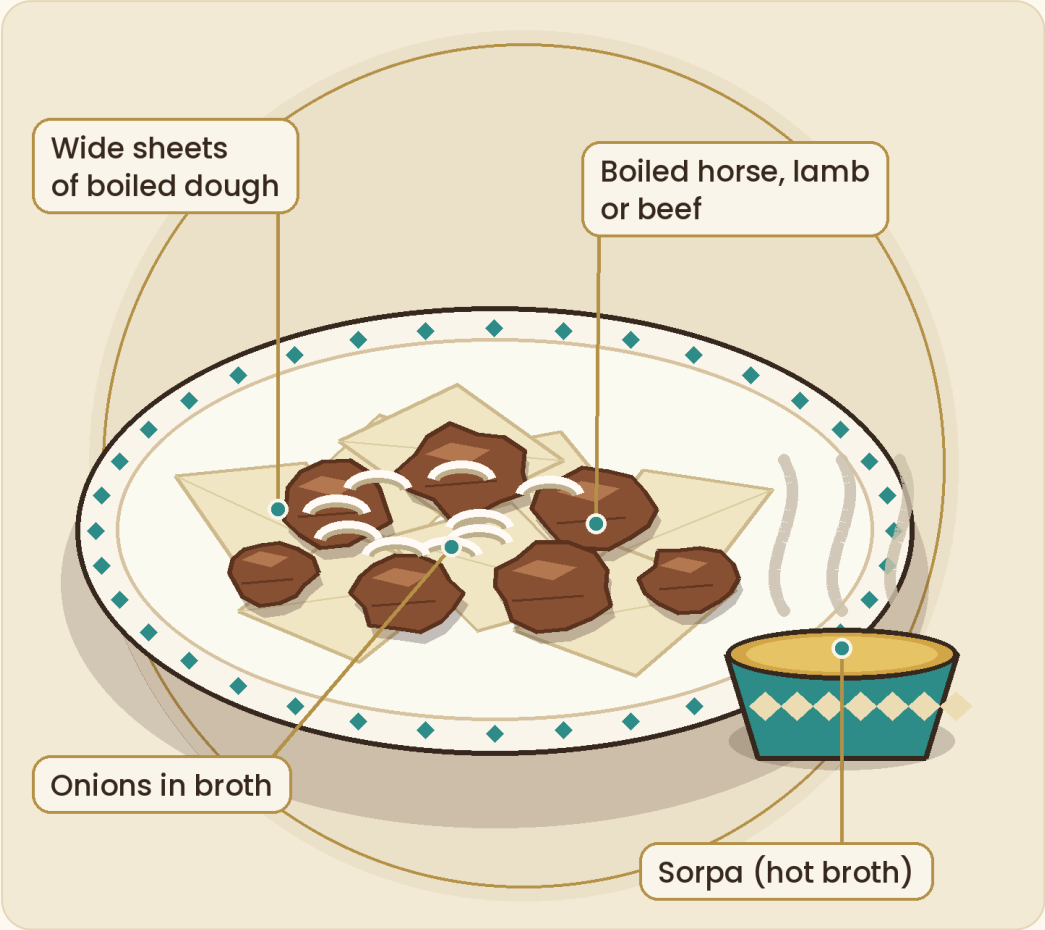
At the wedding, the groom wears the long **shapan** *and a beautifully decorated hat.*

Scan to explore Shapan in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/shapan

Beshbarmak Бесбармақ · *besbarmaq*

The dish of five fingers and shared tables



Beshbarmak, whose name means "five fingers", is the best-known dish of Kazakh hospitality. Nomads traditionally ate it with their hands. Pieces of boiled meat, such as horse, lamb or beef, are served over wide, thin sheets of boiled dough and topped with onions simmered in the broth. A bowl of the rich broth, called sorpa, is served alongside. At the table, the host shares the best cuts to honour the guests and elders. Prepared for weddings, holidays and family gatherings, beshbarmak is a meal about togetherness, generosity and welcoming those who arrive.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The name beshbarmak means "five fingers", recalling how the dish was eaten by hand.
- The broth is served separately in bowls and is called sorpa.
- Serving the best cuts to guests and elders is a sign of respect.

THE WORD IN A SENTENCE

The guest sits at a low table and is served **beshbarmak**, *which means "five fingers": noodles with onions and meat. An elder says a blessing and gives each part of the meal to a different person.*

Scan to explore Beshbarmak in 3D

Turn the 3D model, listen to the recorded word and read more.
kazakhheritage.netlify.app/object/beshbarmak

CREDITS

About this book

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THANK YOU

Rakhmet

Рақмет

The interactive book has a short video, a 3D model and a recorded narration for every word.

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